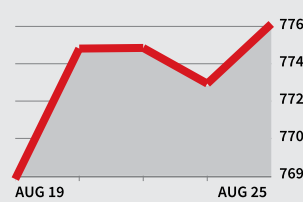


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77656.09 (+286.98)

IN FOCUS



	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24334.55	+115.50
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.57	+0.07
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.41	-0.33
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	161392.00	-113
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	241848.00	-3543



MARKET SWINGS.

Global coking coal prices may remain volatile as weaker steel output and price cuts are offset by China's mine inspections **p10**

SAMUDRA MANTHAN.

Oil Ministry is working on a year-wise roadmap for drilling, seismic surveys, rig deployment **p3**

Persisting retail F&O losses spur call for tighter eligibility filters

STRICTER SCREENING. Income tests and exams mooted to restrict derivatives access to informed investors

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Nearly two years after the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) launched a series of measures to curb excessive retail speculation in the derivatives market, industry participants are increasingly backing tighter eligibility and suitability norms for futures and options (F&O) trading, arguing that participation has fallen but trading behaviour remains largely unchanged.

The latest data have revived calls for stricter entry norms in derivatives trading, with industry participants advocating measures such as income thresholds, investor qualification tests and accredited investor status. The view is that suitability checks and investor profiling may be more effective in protecting retail investors and improving market stability than product-level restrictions alone.

Dhiraj Relli, Managing Director and Chief Executive

Officer of HDFC Securities, said, "There is a need for some more stringent suitability exercises. I am an advocate of suitability." He added that there had been some success from regulatory interventions but more safeguards were required.

HIGH LOSSES

The trigger for the debate is SEBI's latest findings that showed while the number of individual traders fell for the first time in nine years after regulatory intervention, trading behaviour had changed little.

Nearly 97 per cent of retail activity remained concentrated in contracts with less than a week for expiry, while 87.7 per cent of individual traders ended FY26 with losses. The average loss per trader also rose over 2 per cent to ₹1.16 lakh.

A key finding is that derivatives traders with larger underlying equity portfolios tend to fare better than those with little or no cash-equity exposure, strengthening the argument for suitability-based access.

LIKELY DEBATES

- Suitability framework
- Longer-tenor contracts
- Lower margins for longer contracts
- Incentives to deepen cash market
- Active securities lending and borrowing mechanism



"I think the debate on the derivatives framework should continue. SEBI has already taken a number of significant measures, and it is appropriate to assess their impact. At the same time, this market has evolved very rapidly, and the regulatory framework will necessarily need to evolve with it," said Ananth Narayan, former SEBI Whole-Time Member.

The suitability issue is increasingly gaining traction among market intermediaries. "How do we ensure, in a practical and proportionate way, that individuals taking leveraged risks understand those risks and have the financial capacity to bear potential losses? This deserves

continued debate. The challenge is to improve investor protection without creating arbitrary barriers to participation," Narayan said.

SEBI is still grappling with the concerns that prompted its intervention in October 2024, namely heavy retail losses, extremely high volumes in index options on expiry day and the overwhelming preference for ultra-short-term trading strategies.

BALANCING ACT

At the same time, regulators face a delicate balancing act. A significant portion of revenues earned by exchanges, clearing corporations, brokers and other intermedi-

aries is linked to derivatives trading activity.

"A substantial part of the revenues of exchanges, clearing corporations, brokers and other intermediaries is linked to derivatives activity. Sharp changes can, therefore, have consequences for liquidity, market-making and the broader market ecosystem. Necessary regulatory action should not be avoided for that reason, but the consequences need to be understood and changes undertaken in a calibrated manner," Narayan said.

Another challenge is the concentration of trading activity around expiry day. Unlike more developed markets where a substantial share of open interest is either closed or rolled forward before settlement, India's derivatives market continues to see intense activity centred on expiry sessions.

Ashish Nanda, Chief Digital Business Officer at Kotak Securities, said the detailed data could also encourage behavioural changes among retail participants.

Overseas remittances surged 20% in June, led by travel spend, investments

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Indians' overseas investment appetite surged in June, with remittances into foreign equity and debt more than doubling year-on-year to hit a record high of \$457 million. Travel remained the dominant reason for sending money abroad and grew 11 per cent year-on-year.

As per the RBI Bulletin released on Tuesday, the total outward remittances under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) rose by about 20 per cent y-o-y to \$2.5 billion in June. This was up 6 per cent month-on-month.

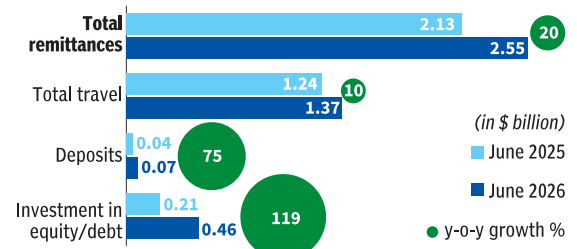
DEPOSITS, INVESTMENTS

The overall growth was driven by sharp increases in remittances towards 'Deposits' and 'Investment in equity and debt', which grew at 75 per cent and 119 per cent y-o-y, respectively, in June.

Investments in equity/debt hit an all-time high of \$457 million. Deposits for June came in at \$71 million, but saw a sharp sequential correction, falling around 40 per cent m-o-m.

Overall, outward remittances under the LRS stood at \$7.2 billion in April-June 2026 compared to \$6.9 billion in the same period of 2025.

Outward remittances under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme



Experts noted that a relatively subdued return profile of Indian equities after a prolonged rally is also likely to have prompted high-net-worth individuals and family offices to diversify globally.

In contrast, many other markets, particularly the US, have offered stronger returns and exposure to sectors such as AI that are under-represented in India.

Sitashwa Srivastava, Founder & CEO of cross-border investing platform Borderless, said that beyond foreign equity markets, there had also been an increased appetite for dollar-linked fixed income investments, given the depreciation of the rupee. Investors are looking to build their portfolios around dollar-denominated debt rather than rupee debt, amid the latter's weakness.

"Within Borderless, since the February-March period,

when the dollar started getting stronger and touching 95-97 range, we have been seeing a considerable interest in keeping dollar deposits and dollar fixed income," he added.

TRAVEL SPEND TOPS

Travel remains the biggest component of outward remittance, accounting for 54 per cent of total remittances at \$1.37 billion in June. This also rose 10 per cent y-o-y and 6 per cent m-o-m, likely due to weak rupee.

Within travel, education-related remittances rose 15 per cent to \$488 million, in line with the beginning of the overseas education season. Business travel was flat and other travel (holidays and other spends) grew 3 per cent at \$853 million.

With inputs from Rohan Das

Also read **p7**

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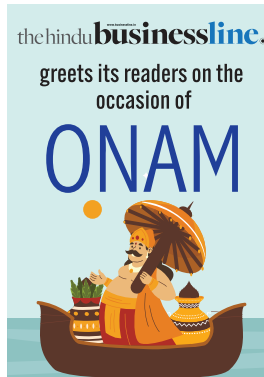
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Pvt firms will soon make missiles with DRDO's tech

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

In a boost to domestic defence manufacturing, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh has approved the transfer of DRDO-developed conven-

tional missile system technology to private firms in the country. The move comes nearly three months after *businessline* broke the story on the government's plan to end defence PSU monopoly in missile manufacturing. On June 5, *businessline* reported

that 10-12 of DRDO's tactical missile-development projects were distributed among two public and four private firms — Adani, Bharat Forge, ICOMM and Solar Defence — based on their capabilities.

Details **p2**

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QUICKLY.

SAFETY DRIVE

Centre mulls random dope testing of all airline pilots

New Delhi: The Centre is considering expanding mandatory drug testing of airline pilots from the existing requirement of 10 per cent to 100 per cent, with testing to be conducted randomly, said Civil Aviation Minister Ram Mohan Naidu. If implemented, India will become the first country to administer such a strict testing regime. According to estimates, India-based airlines currently employ over 11,000 pilots, while the overall numbers range at about 25,000. Naidu said the dope test rule is 10 per cent for pilots, at present, and the government had communicated to the DGCA that it wants every pilot to go through random testing. **p12**

IRAN LINK

US targets four Indian companies

New Delhi: The US has sanctioned four India-based companies for their alleged involvement in importing Iranian petroleum and petrochemical products, as Washington expands its economic pressure on Tehran under a new campaign, Operation Economic Outcast, aimed at choking its finances. India is keeping an eye on the development and waiting for more clarity on the sanctions that have been imposed, sources said. "It is not yet clear what kind of sanctions these are. The notification is awaited," a source tracking the matter told *businessline*. **p9**

QUICKLY.

₹1,755-cr demand notice against Tata Steel stayed



Mumbai: In a major relief for Tata Steel, the Revisional Authority has stayed the ₹1,755 crore demand notice issued by a Jharkhand district office. The company was served a demand notice on April 3 for alleged excess extraction of about 1.62 crore tonnes of mineral coal from its West Bokaro Colliery beyond the permissible limits between FY01 and FY07. The Authority admitted the Revision Application filed by Tata Steel for hearing. **OUR BUREAU**

Suzlon opens wind energy projects worth ₹10,500 cr

Hyderabad: Andhra Pradesh IT Minister Nara Lokesh on Tuesday inaugurated Suzlon's 1,325 MW wind-energy projects in Anantapur, involving an investment of ₹10,500 crore and expected to create 1,600 jobs. He also opened Suzlon's expanded smart blade-making unit with two more production lines. **OUR BUREAU**

Private firms will soon make missiles with DRDO's tech

VALUE ADD. To share conventional systems, including BrahMos, to lift 'sector capability'

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

In a major boost to domestic defence manufacturing, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Tuesday approved the transfer of DRDO-developed conventional missile system technology to private firms in the country. The move comes nearly three months after *businessline* broke the story on the government's plan to end defence PSU monopoly in missile manufacturing.

On June 5, *businessline* reported that 10 to 12 of DRDO's tactical missile development projects were distributed among two public and four private companies — Adani, Bharat Forge, ICOMM, and Solar Defence — based on their capabilities.

This was a deviation from the earlier practice of relying heavily on Bharat Dynamics Ltd., a defence PSU.

"This transfer of technology marks an important milestone in promoting



EARLY SIGNS. *businessline* reported on June 5 that 10 to 12 of DRDO's tactical missile-development projects were distributed to the likes of Adani, Bharat Forge, ICOMM, and Solar Defence **PTI**

greater participation of domestic industries in the defence ecosystem, by enabling them to undertake indigenous production, in accordance with applicable qualifications, certifications, and regulatory requirements," the Ministry said.

MSME PARTICIPATION Conventional missile systems are those that are, or will be, used by the defence forces. These include the BrahMos missile, used most

recently during Operation Sindoor. The others are strategic missiles, specifically those carrying nuclear warheads. These include the Agni series and sea-based or submarine-launched K-series strategic missiles.

The current move enables the successful transition of conventional missile system development to industrial production, reflecting the continued efforts of the DRDO in leveraging the capabilities of the Indian in-

dustry for the development and manufacture of advanced defence systems, the ministry observed.

The objective, it added, is to enhance domestic manufacturing capabilities, strengthen the defence industrial base, and create opportunities for the participation of Indian MSMEs and other technology partners in the supply chain.

TO REDUCE IMPORTS The government's initiative aims to enhance operational capability, reduce import dependence, and increase domestic value addition, while supporting the growth of India's defence manufacturing sector, the ministry noted.

Private industry already collaborates with the DRDO in developing a short-range anti-ship missile and the Rudram I, II, and III series of supersonic and hypersonic ground attack missiles.

The doing away of the entry barrier is also a requirement of the proposed Defence Acquisition Procedure 2026.

Current account balance holds firm despite a flaring trade gap

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

India's current account deficit (CAD) remained contained at \$3.1 billion during the first quarter of FY27, only marginally wider than the \$2.9 billion recorded a year earlier. This, despite a sharp expansion in the merchandise-trade gap, caused by sustained high prices of crude following the West Asia crisis.

DATA FOCUS.

A *businessline* analysis of the latest balance of payments (BoP) data from RBI shows that the goods deficit widened to \$85.7 billion in Q1 from \$68.9 billion in the same quarter last year. On the capital side, the account swung from a net inflow of \$7.4 billion to an outflow of \$5 billion during the period, led by a sharp reversal in foreign portfolio investments (FPI).

SURPLUS TO DEFICIT The CAD-to-GDP ratio has swung sharply in recent quarters.

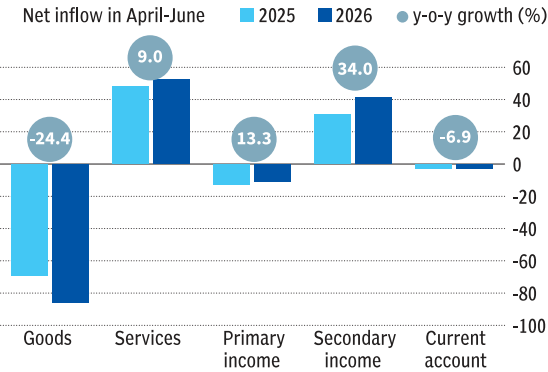
After registering a 0.13 per cent surplus in Q4 FY25, the current account moved into deficit at 0.12 per cent of GDP in Q1 FY26, following Trump's 'Liberation Day' tariff announcement. The imposition of penal tariffs on India for purchasing Russian crude widened it to 0.57 per cent in Q2 before falling to 0.30 per cent in Q3. It then swung back into a 0.36 per cent surplus in Q4 FY26, as the US rolled back some of the tariff hikes and exports to other destinations improved.

The capital account also weakened considerably in Q1 FY27 as FPI flows deteriorated from a \$1.6 billion inflow to a \$9.6 billion outflow in 12 months, while external commercial borrowings (ECBs) moved from a \$5.3 billion inflow to a \$0.1 billion outflow. These were partly

Financial scorecard

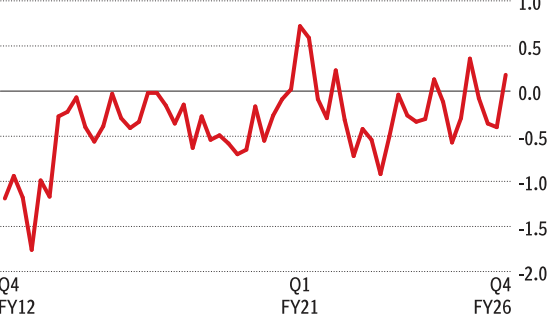
Merchandise trade deficit expands in Q1 FY27

Major components of current account (in \$ billion)



Growing services exports offer some respite

India's current account balance as a % of GDP



Flight of foreign portfolio investments hurt India's capital account in Q1 FY27

Major components of capital account (in \$ billion)

	2025	2026	y-o-y growth (%)
Net inflow in April-June			
Capital account*	7.4	-5.0	-167.6
Foreign Direct Investment	4.8	7.8	62.5
Foreign Portfolio Investment	1.6	-9.6	-700.0
External Commercial Borrowings	5.3	-0.1	-101.9
NRI deposits	3.6	2.8	-22.2

Source: RBI, Bloomberg *Includes other components which recorded outflows during the period

offset by stronger FDI inflows, which rose to \$7.8 billion from \$4.8 billion.

THERE'S SOME HOPE

The future outlook for BoP has improved on some fronts. The net services exports during the quarter stood at about \$52.2 billion compared to \$47.9 billion a year earlier.

Capital inflows have also strengthened. Data from RBI

shows \$65.4 billion flowed through FCNR(B) deposits under its special swap facility by August 21. Additionally, forex inflows through the ECB and OFCB routes also amounted to about \$2.6 billion and \$4.8 billion, respectively, till August 21.

Meanwhile, FPIs invested \$2.3 billion in India in the first three weeks of August, after a \$4.2 billion net investment in July.

No clarity yet on Federal Bank-Jana SFB deal

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Federal Bank on Tuesday said it evaluates various opportunities in the ordinary course for growth and expansion of its business. The bank was reacting to reports that a deal between it and Jana Small Finance Bank (Jana SFB) was likely in advanced stages.

"We clarify that there is no material event/ information that requires disclosure under Regulation 30 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations

and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015," the company said in a regulatory filing.

A POSSIBILITY Referring to Blackstone, one of the world's pre-eminent investment firms, choosing to invest about ₹6,196 crore to acquire up to 9.99 per cent stake in Federal Bank, market players said given this "capital fire power", a deal with Jana SFB could indeed be in the works.

"There is no smoke without fire. And an acquisition by Federal Bank is

REACTION

Federal Bank says it evaluates various opportunities in the ordinary course for growth and business expansion

within the realm of possibility," said an analyst.

S&P Global Ratings recently observed that Federal Bank's preferential issue of warrants to Blackstone will support the bank's above-average growth plans of 14-16 per cent over the next two

years. It noted that Blackstone-managed funds have agreed to purchase 9.99 per cent stake in Federal Bank through a preferential issue of warrants of about ₹6,200 crore.

The bank received a quarter of the committed capital in FY26. The remaining will likely get converted to common equity in FY28.

The bank has the right to call the warrants on an accelerated basis if its regulatory tier-1 capital ratio falls below 13.5 per cent.

Federal Bank shares closed at ₹347.30 apiece,

down 2.96 per cent on the BSE. Jana shares, too, closed down 2.04 per cent at ₹570.30 apiece.

PAST PRECEDENT

In September 2006, the bank acquired Ganesh Bank of Kurundwad. The latter had 32 branches, situated principally in the Kolhapur and Sangli districts of Maharashtra and the adjoining Belgium district of Karnataka.

GBoK's total assets as on March 31, 2005, were at ₹235.44 crore as against total liabilities of ₹220.45 crore.

Va Tech Wabag makes Kuwait debut with desalination plant

Our Bureau
Chennai

Va Tech Wabag, a pure-play multinational water-technology company, on Tuesday signed a contract for the Doha SWRO Desalination Plant with Recarbonation System — Stage II in Kuwait.

The order was awarded to the company in June by the Ministry of Electricity, Water and Renewable Energy, Kuwait, and the project is set to commence now.

Themega project represents Wabag's first project in Kuwait and further strengthens its presence across the GCC region, the company said in a statement.

Undertaken on a Design, Build, Operate basis, the project will be delivered by a Wabag-led unincorporated joint venture with Heavy Engineering Industries and Shipbuilding Company KSC.

The 60 MIGD (approximately 272 MLD) plant will combine Sea Water Reverse Osmosis (SWRO) technology with a recarbonation system, with construction scheduled over 36 months, followed by a five-year operation and maintenance period.

CARBON FOOTPRINT

The company added that on-site solar photovoltaic systems will meet part of the plant's energy needs, supporting Kuwait's clean-energy objectives, while lowering the facility's carbon footprint.

Mondelez India, Amway, others took corrective action after notices: FSSAI

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Continuing with its updates on the ongoing crackdown, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on Tuesday said many major food business operators have taken corrective actions after notices were issued.

This includes withdrawing of misleading label claims and revising product packaging to ensure consumer safety and regulatory compliance.

In a social media post, FSSAI said Mondelez India Foods, known for brands such as Cadbury and Bournvita, has ensured compliance by withdrawing misleading health claims and nutrient comparative claims. It has also removed misleading ads from e-commerce platforms.



THE FIX. Measures by firms include retracting misleading claims and revising packaging, said the regulator **GETTY IMAGES**

Meanwhile, the food regulator said nutritional-supplement maker Sapiens Labs has also withdrawn all misleading claims and ads.

NO MORE 'ENERGY'

Similarly, Amway India, which sells dietary supplements and other edible products, has removed "100 per cent" claims from product packaging and promotional materials and has

assured that it has discontinued the sales of old stocks. It also informed FSSAI that a revised packaging without such claims was finalised, which will be rolled out in the next couple of months.

"Amway India Enterprises has accepted the directions and taken down the term "energy drink" on its XS product range. Clarifying that the descriptor was used in good faith following FSSAI's March 2024 advisory, Amway has voluntarily revised its product artwork, website, and promotional materials to remove the word energy," FSSAI noted in its social media post.

Similarly, Kerala-based Juza Foods, too, has agreed to remove misleading health claims, including 100 per cent Vegan and other related claims, the FSSAI noted. Juza Foods makes baby food powders and blends.

IPO-bound ESDS flags local protest impact on data-centre biz

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Data centre player and AI ecosystem provider ESDS Software Solutions has flagged protests by residents in India against data centres as a financial and strategic risk to its business.

"Protests by local residents and activists against the opening of new data centres in India could adversely affect our ability to open new data centres," the company said in its red herring prospectus (RHP) filed on Tuesday with the SEBI. "Further, such protests, whether or not directed specifically at our company or our projects, may adversely affect the reputation and brand of our company, and could adversely affect our relationships with regulators, cus-

tomers, business partners, employees, and other stakeholders," it added.

The company is one of the only two players in India providing the entire spectrum of GPUaaS, cloud, managed services, data-centre infrastructure, and software solutions and the largest in terms of revenue from operations in FY26, as per its filings. ESDS' latest IPO filing has increased the offering's size to ₹720 crore from the ₹600 crore it considered last year.

NO FRESH WATER

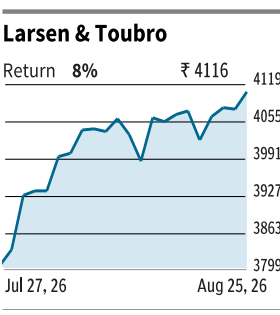
Until last year, data centre players were not worried about local dissent against setting them up, Piyush Somani, Promoter, Chairman, and Managing Director at ESDS, told *businessline*.

"The protests were not there [in the DRHP] before.

However, following the recent protests, we felt it was necessary to disclose and highlight the issue. Moving forward, we will ensure that data centres come in a proper industrial township and we don't need any fresh water, no effluents flowing out of the data centre, no pollution. Anyway, all our data centres are either in in-

dustrial areas or IT parks," said Somani.

ESDS plans to set up more data centres in Saibabad in Uttar Pradesh and Kolkata. Water consumption, power-grid strain, land acquisition, and displacement were among the key concerns flagged by the protesters across India. Regardless of the risks, Somani remained



KEY REGION

West Asia contributed more than a third to the company's topline in FY26

derground cables," the company said.

The three projects will collectively contribute to 6 GWh (gigawatt-hour) of storage capacity, marking one of the most impactful

resolute on the potential of the data centre business.

ESDS has fixed the price band of ₹408-429 per equity share, allowing investors to bid for a minimum of 34 equity shares.

MARRIED TO MARKET

"There is a lot of excitement in the market. The reason we are getting married to the market is that married people are trusted more. We want to make sure that international and domestic customers feel comfortable doing business with us," said Somani. Earlier, analysts pointed out that the lack of data centre stocks in India creates hurdles for investors in assessing the market.

ESDS will use the IPO proceeds to procure 600-800 GPUs, the MD said. The issue will open on August 28 and close on September 1.

CNH to invest ₹1,000 crore to double tractor output

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

US-based CNH Industrial is planning to invest around ₹1,000 crore to double its tractor-manufacturing capacity in India by 2030. The move is also expected to increase its market share to around 10 per cent.

The company will spend an additional ₹1,000 crore in the next five years in product development and R&D, said Narinder Mittal, President and MD, CNH Industrial (India). "We have a tractor-production capacity of 70,000 per annum. We are planning to increase it to around 1.4 lakh by 2030. We will be setting up a greenfield plant, close to our existing plant in Greater Noida," said Mittal.



Narinder Mittal, President & MD, CNH Industrial India

The company has around 5 per cent market share in India, in terms of volume. "We aim to be in double digits in four to five years," Mittal said.

In India, CNH manufactures CASE brand tractors for Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and other markets. The company sold around 48,000 tractors in the domestic market and exported 10,600 units in calendar year 2025.

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CM

YK

Samudra Manthan scheme: Govt prepares year-wise drilling, rig deployment roadmap

OFFSHORE BOOST. Oil Ministry eyes higher oil and gas production in deep and ultra deep waters

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Oil Ministry is working on a year-wise execution roadmap for drilling, seismic surveys and rig deployment under its ambitious \$8.8 billion Samudra Manthan, or the National Offshore Exploration Scheme.

Leveraging the funding boost, the Ministry eyes higher oil and gas production in the deep and ultra deep waters.

Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri met top Ministry officials and PSU executives earlier this week to review the action taken on the decisions from the two recent brainstorming sessions at Gurugram (Haryana) and Duliyan (Assam).

Puri said the progress in the implementation of the

Samudra Manthan Scheme was discussed.

The Ministry has decided to pursue a year-wise roadmap, which is now being finalised to drive accelerated drilling, seismic surveys and rig deployment across the KG, Mahanadi, Andaman and Cauvery basins, the Minister said.

State-run exploration and production majors — ONGC and Oil India (OIL) — will be the driving force behind the scheme, Puri added.

KEY INFRASTRUCTURE

Backing this effort is a dedicated ONGC-led JV for drill-ship capacity, addressing a key infrastructure bottleneck through shared investment and long-term chartering, he said.

Motilal Oswal Financial Services, in a recent report, noted that ONGC shall be



MAJOR PLAYERS. ONGC and Oil India will be the driving force behind the Samudra Manthan scheme

playing a major role in Samudra Manthan.

“ONGC expects oil prices to settle at \$75 per barrel in the long run. That will help ONGC undertake exploration activities (including deep water exploration) which were not viable financially at \$60-65,” the brokerage explained.

With ₹84,000 crore fund

(Phase-I valid till FY31) from the government, the opportunity seems very lucrative for ONGC.

Each deep water will cost around ₹1,000 crore. Support will be coming from the government, but the quantum and timelines are still not disclosed. Some global players might come, it added. The scheme provides

funds for offshore seismic data acquisition especially in erstwhile No-Go zones, which is a key issue hampering commercial exploitation of oil and gas reserves in these areas due to lack of good prospectivity data.

Samudra Manthan provides support for drilling deepwater/ultra-deepwater wells where the domestic upstream sector has limited experience and technical expertise and exploitation of the same remains highly capital intensive and risky.

It aims to add incremental annual production of 10-15 million tonnes of oil equivalent (MTOE) that can potentially reduce India's high import dependence on crude oil and natural gas.

EXPLORATION DRIVE

The scheme will deploy a comprehensive set of inter-

ventions across the offshore exploration value chain including large-scale acquisition, processing and interpretation of high-quality seismic data.

It will also include accelerated deepwater and ultra-deepwater exploratory drilling, scientific drilling in frontier basins, development of common offshore production and evacuation infrastructure, and establishment of an integrated oil & gas manufacturing and services zone.

Samudra Manthan also includes dedicated provisions for digital programme management, capacity building, technology adoption, stakeholder engagement and international outreach, creating an integrated ecosystem to accelerate offshore exploration and production in the country.

Jaishankar calls for urgent steps to address \$50-b India-Russia trade deficit



BOOSTING TIES. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov in Moscow PTI

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

With India's trade deficit with Russia widening to over \$50 billion in 2025-26 from just \$6.6 billion five years earlier, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar called for urgent steps to rebalance the rapidly expanding bilateral trade, including greater market access, removal of tariff and non-tariff barriers, stronger payment mechanisms and deeper business-to-business engagement.

“Addressing this imbalance is today one of our foremost priorities,” Jaishankar said in his opening remarks at the 27th session of the India-Russia Inter-Governmental Commission on Trade, Economic, Scientific, Technological and Cultural Cooperation (IRIGC-TEC) in Moscow.

SKewed Growth

Bilateral goods trade has more than quadrupled during the period to nearly \$60 billion in FY26. This growth, however, has been highly skewed, with India's imports from Russia at \$55.3 billion, dominated by oil, while its exports were just \$4.5 billion.

“Progress on market access, removal of tariff and non-tariff barriers, strengthening payment mechanisms, and stronger business-to-business engagement will be critical for addressing this imbalance and achieving our

shared objective of \$100 billion in bilateral trade by 2030,” the Minister said.

Russia's emphasis on taking forward bilateral cooperation in many domains from energy, nuclear, metallurgy, space, railways, fertilizers to mobility of skills, to connectivity, and to payment mechanisms, was reciprocated by Jaishankar.

Jaishankar wrapped up his two-day visit to Moscow on Monday where he held a series of high-level meetings, including with Russian President Vladimir Putin.

Jaishankar's visit to Russia took place amid threats from the US on possible economic sanctions for continuing to trade in crude oil with Moscow. “The complicated international scenario will constantly throw up fresh ideas because we are all focused on de-risking and diversifying. Economic demands and technology requirements will add to this mix,” the Minister said.

FTA PUSH

He also said India and Russia could take stock of negotiations on the proposed India-Eurasian Economic Union (EaEU) Free Trade Agreement as part of efforts to expand market access.

Jaishankar proposed a greater focus on implementation and outcomes through the IRIGC-TEC mechanism, asking its working groups and sub-groups to prioritise specific deliverables before the next session.

Indian refiners lean on Russia, UAE, South America for August crude oil imports

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Indian refiners are procuring crude oil cargoes from Russia, the UAE and South America during August as disruptions persist in West Asia following the conflict impacting supplies through the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) and the Bab-el-Mandeb (BeM).

Sources pointed out that disruptions due to the West Asia conflict have impacted supplies from the region forcing vessels to take longer routes to bypass conflict zones.

“In such a scenario, Indian refiners have diversified supplies towards Russia, the UAE, West Africa and South

India's crude oil imports (Thousand barrels per day — kb/d)			
	August 2026 (till August 24) (P)	July 2026	June 2026
Russia	1,982	2,619	2,637
UAE	611	470	513
Saudi Arabia	385	390	293
Iraq	89	129	67
US	116	125	157
Nigeria	129	95	69
Brazil	120	199	230
Venezuela	383	218	281
Angola	45	31	64

Source: Kpler; (P): Provisional

America. Russian oil, as usual, is the main base followed by the UAE, Brazil and Venezuela. Sweet crude is coming from Nigeria, Angola and the US,” explained one of the sources.

Kpler said that despite the threat of the Graham Bill and

potential secondary tariffs, Russia remains India's largest crude supplier.

“The important distinction here is between policy risk and an immediate physical disruption to trade,” said the global real time data and analytics provider.

Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modeling, told *businessline*, “Indian refiners typically procure crude several weeks in advance, so even if policy pressure increases, the adjustment would not necessarily be visible immediately in arrival data. We do not expect Russian imports to ease currently, given the overall global crude supply situation remains constrained.”

RESILIENCE OF UAE

Replacing Russian crude completely would be challenging, particularly while Middle Eastern supply and logistics remain constrained. Replacing Russian barrels is technically feasible, but economically and politically

fraught, he emphasised. Another important trend, noted Ritolia, is the resilience of the UAE crude oil supplies to India.

“The UAE barrels continue to gain traction as the country has been relatively successful in maintaining exports despite regional disruptions, supported by pipeline infrastructure to Fujairah and offshore/ship-to-ship logistics outside the SoH.

“This has allowed UAE crude flows to India to remain comparatively strong at a time when availability from several other Middle Eastern suppliers has been constrained,” he added.

What is worrying is the rising cost of buying crude oil at a time when rupee is

weak against the US dollar, adversely impacting India's import bill and current account deficit (CAD).

Tightening physical supplies are pushing up risk premiums on Middle East Gulf (MEG) and West African barrels, while at the same time Russian discounts are drying up and the lower price advantage on Venezuelan crude is shrinking fast.

Another development that can further add up to the cost of procuring crude oil is the latest US sanctions on Iran. If the sanctions impact China's sourcing from the Persian Gulf nation, the reshuffling would lead to higher prices as India will have to compete for alternative sources.



DRIVING THE VISION FORWARD

Excerpts of Chairman's Message at the 39th Annual General Meeting held on 25th August, 2026

Shri. Manoj Kumar Dubey
Chairman and Managing Director & CEO
DIN: 07518387

Chairman's message

Dear Shareholders,

I am privileged to present the 39th Annual Report of Indian Railway Finance Corporation Limited (IRFC), India's premier infrastructure financing institution & the backbone of Indian Railways. Achievements of FY 25-26 are not just numbers – they are stories of ambition turned into action. As we step into the future, IRFC 2.0 stands committed to fuelling India's growth, financing tomorrow, and empowering generations to come.

It gives me great satisfaction in sharing that we exceeded our guidance in FY 2025–26, creating an additional sanction pipeline of ₹72,949 crore against the target of ₹60,000 crore and achieving disbursements of ₹35,067 crore against the guidance of ₹30,000 crore. This outperformance reflects the Company's strong execution capabilities, efficient fund mobilization, and its pivotal role in meeting the financing needs of Indian Railways and allied infrastructure.

FY 2025–26 was distinguished as a breakthrough year for IRFC, delivering its highest-ever results in terms of revenue being ₹27,284.15 crore, Profit After Tax being ₹7,009.17 crore, Net Worth being ₹56,748.76 crore, AUM being ₹4.85 Lakh crore and EPS being ₹5.36/-. With a CRAR of 110.91% and zero NPAs, we reaffirmed the strength of our model and disciplined governance. Beyond stellar results, IRFC scripted capital market milestones – making a triumphant return to the ECB market after three years and pioneering its debut in Zero Coupon Bonds, expanding the frontiers of infrastructure financing with innovation and leadership.

Our focus on efficiency and cost optimization enabled consistent value creation, including a record dividend payout of ₹2,744.38 crore (₹2.10 per share) viz. 31% higher than FY 2024–25, reflecting our commitment to rewarding shareholders. Guided by the vision of 'IRFC 2.0', we advanced our transformation journey, diversifying into allied infrastructure sectors and engaging global investors through international borrowings and strategic roadshows, positioning IRFC as a future-ready institution aligned with India's development priorities.

As India marches towards Viksit Bharat 2047, IRFC stands uniquely positioned to power this transformation – with a strong balance sheet, zero-NPA record, and unwavering commitment to sustainable growth, innovation, and value creation. The conferment of 'Navratna' status by the Government of India in the previous year further enhanced our agility and strategic capabilities, empowering us to seize new opportunities.

I invite you to explore this Annual Report, confident that the foundations we have laid today will support even greater structures of achievement tomorrow. Together, we are not just financing projects – we are building the enduring architecture of India's future.

KEY FINANCIALS

	Mar-25	Mar-26	
REVENUE (in ₹ crore)	27,152	27,284	↑ 0.49%
PAT (in ₹ crore)	6,502	7,009	↑ 7.80%
AUM (in ₹ crore)	4,60,048	4,84,617	↑ 5.34%
NET WORTH (in ₹ crore)	52,667	56,748	↑ 7.75%
EPS (₹)	4.98	5.36	↑ 7.63%



MoU Rating

The Company enters Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Ministry of Railways (MoR) every year wherein Company is evaluated on various financial and non-financial parameters. Based on its performance, the Company has been rated 'Excellent' by the Department of Public Enterprises (DPE) for the year 2024-25.

Lending & Borrowing Portfolio:

Total Disbursements during FY 2025-26 stood at ₹35,067 crore, including ₹12,386 towards railways, ₹9,516 crore towards Power and ₹13,165 towards fertilizers. No disbursement was made to the Ministry of Railways (MoR) due to a 'NIL' target allocation for the year. The diversification-led expansion resulted in improved spreads and a consistent rise in net interest margin (NIM), while IRFC maintained its pristine zero NPA status.

The Company mobilised ₹46,263.69 crore through diversified instruments, including taxable bonds (₹13,575.42 crore), rupee term loans (₹23,950 crore), S4EC bonds (₹2,306.21 crore), and ECBs (₹6,432.06 crore). The diversified borrowing mix supported financial flexibility, competitive cost and efficient asset-liability management.

Business Diversification

During FY 25-26, the company executed twelve (12) financing agreements beyond conventional railway financing worth ₹72,949 crore, significantly scaling its diversified lending portfolio. Notably, over 75% of business has been acquired through competitive RFPs.

Among key transactions, IRFC refinanced Dedicated Freight Corridor Corporation of India Limited's (DFCCIL) World Bank exposure through a ₹9,821 crore long-term rupee facility, resulting in savings of approximately ₹2,700 crore for DFCCIL. In line with its strategy to diversify into rail-linked infrastructure financing, IRFC also sanctioned a ₹12,640 crore loan to CSPGCL and committed financing of close to ₹15,000 crore to MAHAGENCO for its power generation projects, further strengthening IRFC's presence in the energy infrastructure space. The company also executed a ₹12,842 crore refinancing deal for Hindustan Urvarak & Rasayan Limited (HURL), marking its entry into large-ticket refinancing in the fertilizer sector.

The diversification strategy has begun to materially improve profitability metrics, with higher-yielding assets contributing to enhanced spreads compared to the traditional cost-plus railway financing model.

Road Ahead

IRFC enters FY 2026–27 with strengthened financial capacity, supported by a Board-approved borrowing limit of ₹70,000 Crore. With its elevation to Navratna CPSE status, IRFC gains greater autonomy to pursue new opportunities, refinance borrowings, and diversify into broader infrastructure sectors. The Company expects growth to accelerate in the coming years, supported by a steady pipeline and emerging opportunities in sectors such as metro and ports, in line with its whole-of-government approach.

Going forward, IRFC aims to play a larger role in financing nation-building infrastructure projects by providing long-term and competitively priced financing solutions. Key focus areas would include railway infrastructure, Metro Rail projects, Regional Rapid Transit Systems (RRTS), dedicated freight corridors, high-speed rail corridors, ports, Multi-Modal Logistics Parks (MMLPs), renewable energy, railway SPVs and other infrastructure projects having strategic linkages with the railway sector. Through such financing, IRFC seeks to contribute towards improving logistics efficiency, strengthening multimodal connectivity and supporting sustainable economic growth.

Acknowledgement

It is with great pride and humility that I acknowledge the unwavering support and trust bestowed upon IRFC by our valued shareholders, debenture-holders, investors, and lending institutions, our customers and partners, especially Indian Railways, for their steadfast collaboration and longstanding association during the financial year 2025–26.

I extend my heartfelt gratitude to the Hon'ble Minister of Railways and Hon'ble Minister of Finance, along with all officials of their ministries, for their continued guidance and vision. Their insights and leadership have been instrumental in positioning IRFC as a key enabler of infrastructure transformation.

I also express gratitude to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (C&AG), the Statutory Auditors, Secretarial Auditors, and Internal Auditors for their commitment to transparency, accountability, and good governance, and for their valuable support and guidance throughout the year.

I wish to place on record my appreciation for the Company's Board of Directors for their strategic oversight, and our employees whose professionalism, dedication, and commitment have been critical in navigating challenges and delivering consistent performance.

We remain deeply committed to driving the nation's growth journey through strategic financial solutions and prudent governance.

Regards,

Sd/-
Shri Manoj Kumar Dubey
Chairman and Managing Director & CEO
DIN: 07518387

Date: 25th August, 2026
Place: New Delhi

Note: This does not purport to form proceedings of this Annual General Meeting

Scan the QR Code to ▶ read full speech







INDIAN RAILWAY FINANCE CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Navratna CPSE under Ministry of Railways) CIN: L65910DL1986GOI1026363
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Unkind cut

Bank levy on cash withdrawals is unfair

State Bank of India, the country’s largest bank, has decided to charge even basic savings account holders for cash withdrawals beyond a minimum count. Come October 1, basic savings bank deposit account (BSBDA), or no-frills account-holders, will have to shell out ₹15 per withdrawal plus GST when they use ATMs to withdraw cash more than four times a month. The move is unfair, defies logic — and must be withdrawn.



It punishes those in the lower rungs of our socio-economic pyramid who operate low balance accounts, and lack the confidence and the means to go cashless. Informal sector workers — whose livelihoods remain overwhelmingly cash-dependent — prefer to withdraw currency on a need basis. The Reserve Bank of India, in fact, acknowledges that cash remains central to India’s economy, as reflected in its Deputy Governor Shishir Chandra Murmu’s recent emphasis on the importance of cash in rural and semi-urban regions, among low-income households, senior citizens and small businesses. These sections can ill-afford such penalties. The national database of informal workers boasts in excess of 31 crore registrations. By February 2026, India had about 58 crore Jan-Dhan accounts (which are a subset of basic accounts) with a deposit balance of ₹2.94 lakh crore. Of these, nearly 78 per cent have been opened in rural and semi-urban areas. SBI alone witnesses about 32 crore transactions daily in these accounts.

Affluent consumers evade these penalties by seamlessly transitioning to digital channels. A salaried account holder incurs no charge when paying ₹500 via UPI for coffee at a five-star restaurant, regardless of transaction frequency. Conversely, a casual labourer who must rely on micro-ATMs or business correspondents using Aadhaar authentication for basic cash access will end up facing punitive charges. Both digital and physical payment mechanisms are merely delivery channels; a digital nudge is fine, but penalising consumers for choosing one over the other isn’t. In the UK, a mature economy where cash usage remains substantial, banks do not charge customers for accessing their funds. Coercive steps can nudge citizens to hold currency rather than deposit it in banks.

Penalties should also be abolished for failing to maintain minimum account balances. As with withdrawal levies, these again hurt those that are not well-to-do — and are not informed upfront about such rules. It is hard to understand what is driving SBI (and other banks) to scrounge around for ‘fee income’ by taking harsh steps, when its quarterly profit is of the order of ₹20,000 crore. The country’s largest lender earned a mere ₹286 crore via ATM charges, and ₹232 crore from minimum balance penalties for FY26. Low-cost current account and savings account (CASA) deposits, at about ₹22.6 lakh crore for FY26, accounted for about 45 per cent of SBI’s loan advances. It is only fair that lay depositors are treated better.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

Build the weapons independence Kyiv needs

The events of the past few days on Europe’s borders may mark a turning point in Russia’s war on Ukraine. While the political skies in Kyiv have darkened for Ukraine’s Volodymyr Zelenskyy, the military picture looks brighter. Ukraine can already send swarms of drones against Russian oil facilities, e-commerce warehouses and airfields. Andy Burnham’s arrival in Kyiv marks a step forward. Britain is releasing classified information on its components of Scalp, the French version of the Anglo-French Storm Shadow cruise missile, enabling its assembly in Ukraine. This is more than another weapon for Kyiv. Britain is helping Ukraine become less dependent on the western armory. Moscow sabre-rattles, but Britain should hold its nerve. Kyiv has been at the mercy of its allies, waiting to replenish weapons stockpiles and release sophisticated arms. LONDON, AUGUST 24



US needs an exit ramp, not an ‘economic D-Day’ for Iran

Watching a superpower that cannot win a conflict pretend it can win an economic siege would be comic if it weren’t so tragic. That is what we witnessed this week, when US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent stepped forward to declare the “single greatest financial offensive ever marshaled against an adversary” — in this case Iran — only to acknowledge that Washington was not actually naming the countries to be punished or imposing secondary sanctions yet. There would be a “cure period”. The penalties would come later. Washington wants to convince Tehran that tougher measures are coming while keeping its own options open. But the much-hyped “economic D-Day” looks more like a damp squib. The United States’ latest campaign targets almost 60 individuals, entities and vessels and expands the reach into digital assets, gold, technology, aviation and shipping. BEIJING, AUGUST 25

India’s task as a late industrialiser

INDUSTRY GOALS. India needs to step up its industrial policy to compete with developed nations and create jobs for its youth



PRITAM BANERJEE

Every major economy is adopting large-scale industrial policy (IP) and state support to navigate rapid technological change. Historically such policies helped late industrialisers catch up with frontier economies. Since the 2010s, though, it is the dominant players, those who already hold technological leadership, who are deploying IP most aggressively, deepening their edge further. Unlike tariffs, which simply let local firms compete better against foreign rivals at home, effective state support and IP helps firms compete globally. The EU, US, Japan and China together account for over 90 per cent of global industrial policy spending; developing countries, India included account for less than 10 per cent. India’s flagship schemes — PLI, the Bhavya Industrial Park scheme, the Electronics Components Manufacturing Scheme, the RDI Scheme — are a fraction of the scale of IP programmes in advanced economies or China. India fiscally cannot match the budgets or scope of industrial policy in the US, China or the large EU states. That raises hard questions about the policy space India needs to build scale and reach the technology frontier. These questions matter because India’s economic rise, and its ability to employ its vast youth population, depends on getting this right.

WHERE INDIA STANDS
UNIDO data show India trailing its G20 peers across most industrial sectors. It

doesn’t rank among the top five global producers in upstream industries such as metal fabrication, electronics, or industrial machinery. Even where it does break into the top five: chemicals, basic metals, pharmaceuticals, its share of G20 output stays below 5 per cent, and its global share is smaller still. The data also reveal a conversion problem: India struggles to turn upstream scale into downstream competitiveness. It is the world’s third-largest producer of basic metals by value yet ranks only tenth in fabricated metals. Its strength in textiles doesn’t carry through to apparel. China dominates global industrial output, holding 50 per cent or more of world production across most sectors, followed by the US and EU. Despite talk of American de-industrialisation, the US still ranks among the top three producers in most industries. As these dominant players plan for even greater scale, India’s task as a late industrialiser only gets harder. Most industrial sectors are also undergoing technological transformation, and Indian industry will need to close the gap with the frontier. Talent isn’t the constraint. In high-specification machining and nanoscale materials, two illustrative frontier fields, the Australian Strategic Policy Institute’s Critical Technology Tracker ranks Indian researchers second

India struggles to turn upstream scale into downstream competitiveness.
It is the world’s third-largest producer of basic metals by value yet ranks only tenth in fabricated metals

only to China, producing roughly 10 per cent of published and cited research and training around 10 per cent of the world’s postgraduate talent in these areas. What India lacks is China’s manufacturing ecosystem to absorb that talent into downstream production. Indian talent instead flows to global multinationals or into Global Capability Centres serving those same MNCs. Start-up culture in manufacturing remains nascent, pockets of success aside, with nothing close to China’s programmatic push or the EU’s newly ambitious industrial policy. India’s FTA strategy aims to lock in binding, predictable market access across every G20 economy and major region by 2027-28, ensuring a level playing field with competitors. But FTAs will also open India’s domestic market to foreign competition. Manufacturers currently based in China will relocate production to India’s FTA partners, and Chinese firms themselves will do the same, as their exports face tariff and non-tariff barriers elsewhere. Indian industry needs to be competition-ready on scale, quality and technology. Investment sits at the centre of this strategy. Policymakers hope that FTA enabled duty-free import of intermediates and duty-free export of finished goods, combined with India’s domestic market and demographic advantage, will form the “trifecta” for attracting global investment. But that bet rests on one assumption: that India’s cost and ease of doing business won’t outweigh these advantages. If it fails that test, firms will use FTAs to serve the Indian market from elsewhere rather than invest here.

THREE URGENT PRIORITIES
Smarter industrial policy: Small and mid-sized firms require fiscally

sustainable support. Focus should be on patient, low-cost capital for R&D, tooling, quality upgrades, and technology adoption. Instead of generic schemes, India needs targeted missions in core areas of niche manufacturing such as advanced ceramics, nanomaterials, and precision machining. These should back designated champion firms and be monitored independently by a joint government-industry body housed outside Ministries running such schemes, such as NITI Aayog. **Coordinated ease of doing business:** Every investment, foreign and domestic, above ₹500 crore should get a dedicated central case officer from DPIIT plus two State-level officers to support time-bound execution. These officers and their department heads would be accountable to screening committees of non-bureaucrat professionals, with real consequences for career progression for non-performance. **Treat major manufacturers as nation-builders:** Manufacturers with over ₹200 crore turnover should receive Authorized Economic Operator (AEO) equivalent status, granting green channel customs clearance and GST priority processing. Unresolved issues pending over two weeks will escalate to independent expert-led tribunals. Though daunting in India’s current context, these decisive reforms would signal true seriousness. The window to build scale and competitiveness is narrowing. By 2030, India’s goal should be 10,000 global champions delivering \$2 trillion in merchandise exports and 25 million manufacturing jobs.

The writer was formerly Head, Centre for WTO Studies, IIFT

Repowering Tamil Nadu’s wind power sector

The new TN govt must move fast in reviving wind energy, where its ‘first mover advantage’ is in danger of running out

Ravichandran Purushothaman

A wind farm owner in Tirunelveli put it to me bluntly: his turbines were commissioned at a time when mobile phones were still a novelty. Today, those machines generate barely a third of what a modern turbine could produce on the same site. He has been trying to repower the project for two years. But the process involves navigating multiple clearances, renegotiating power purchase agreements and securing exemptions on turbine spacing. While these issues remain unresolved, the wind continues to blow, but its potential remains largely untapped. Every season of delay means lost generation, lost revenue and clean energy capacity that India cannot afford to leave unused. That is the real cost of delay in Tamil Nadu’s renewable-energy story. This is not a resource problem. It is a speed problem. Every month a 1990s-era turbine operates at a fraction of its potential is a month of lost export competitiveness for the MSME down the road, paying ₹8 a unit for electricity while its Vietnamese competitor pays ₹2.80. Leadership in this sector is about compressing the two-year concept-to-commissioning timeline for wind, clearing the paperwork queue, and

making land, substations and PPAs ready before the investor asks for them — not after. Where wind parks with pre-built substations and secured right-of-way are offered to investors, projects can move from intent to capacity in months, not years — because the constraint is administrative readiness, not investor appetite. PSUs such as NTPC have signalled real interest in Tamil Nadu’s wind and solar parks. That interest has a shelf life. Capital goes where the runway is already built. None of these fixes is a complicated engineering problem. They are decisions waiting for someone senior enough to take ownership, set a deadline and drive them through. These are: (i) Relax the spacing rule: The Tamil Nadu Electricity Regulatory Commission and the Tamil Nadu Energy Development Agency should jointly notify a repowering-specific relaxation of the 5D x 7D spacing rule at high-wind sites. If treated as a priority rather than another item in the backlog, it can be delivered within a quarter. (ii) Stand up a Wind and Solar Parks Corporation — Tangedco, Tantransco and the State Energy Department, with PowerGrid at the table from day one. Tamil Nadu needs a TIDCO-style entity with a clear mandate to develop renewable-energy parks and coordinate the common infrastructure around



WIND ENERGY. Time for reboot

them. It needs a founding order, not another feasibility study. PowerGrid should be brought into the design stage so that substations and evacuation infrastructure are built to interstate-ready specifications from the outset, rather than retrofitted later. The target should be clear: the first 1,000 MW of park capacity should be leased within 18 months, not after another multi-year development cycle. (iii) Fix PPAs and banking: The Indian Wind Turbine Manufacturers Association and CII Southern Region can bring the concerns of single-owner projects and MSME captive users directly into that process, rather than leaving them to years of representations. This is the one issue that needs political weight, not just bureaucratic follow-up. A State government delegation making the case directly to

the Union Ministry of Power and the Central Electricity Authority, with the Southern Regional Power Committee providing the technical backing, can achieve more than another round of letters moving through official channels. The ask should be specific: a defined transmission roadmap, committed capacity and a clear implementation timeline for Tamil Nadu’s next phase of renewable growth. This issue has been raised for more than a decade. It now needs a named owner, a defined roadmap and a deadline — not another place in the queue. Tamil Nadu’s new government has a window of opportunity and needs to move quickly and demonstrate results before inertia sets in. Repowering is close to the perfect early win. It needs no new tax, no land acquisition battle and no ideological confrontation. What it requires is regulatory clarity, administrative coordination and the will to move agencies that already exist in the same direction. Deliver it in year one, and it becomes a proof point for how this government can get stalled infrastructure moving elsewhere too. The risk is leaving it on the table long enough for the wind, quite literally, to move on without us.

The writer is President, Danfoss India, and Chairman - CII Southern region

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

The UPI journey

The article ‘UPI — an eventful journey’ (August 25) discusses the impact of UPI. It has been instrumental in accelerating the formalisation of the economy and increasing financial inclusion, alongside the Jan Dhan Yojana. Its integration with various government and public services has enhanced daily life. Organised, simplified transaction records under it help users gain greater control over their spending while avoiding the risks of keeping physical cash. Auto-pay features help prevent missed payments. Banks benefit from reduced cash-handling needs. There has also been increased

adoption of digital technology among rural folk. Additionally, the need to visit ATMs solely for cash withdrawals has declined sharply, indicating that the country is progressing towards a less-cash economy. **Kamal Laddha**
Bengaluru

Premature exits
This refers to the front page news report “‘CEO exits rise at India Inc.; stocks feel investor heat” (August 25). The premature exit of CEOs has other causes also — institutional investors’ impatience for faster results, heightened focus on governance of companies facing

regulatory or reputation challenges and close monitoring of governance and performance by analysts. The negative impact could also be high — investors perceive it as a risk signal in the path of strategy execution. It affects their trust due to leadership instability. The perceived execution threat is enhanced because of leadership change midstream. And it precipitates talent wars between companies. **YG Chouksey**
Pune

Game for the fittest
This refers to the Editorial ‘Exercise other options’ (August 25). Option trading should not be regarded as

speculation. The purpose and structure of the position determine whether it is speculative or not. For example, an investor who holds shares of a particular company may buy a Put Option on those shares to protect against a potential decline in their value, or sell a Call Option to generate additional income. It is a strategy of risk management. By contrast, naked options positions and purely directional option trading are generally more speculative in nature. Measures like increasing the contract value may not yield the desired results as the habitual or speculative option traders could simply shift to far out-of-the-money

(OTM) options, where the premium requirement is relatively lower, depending on their available capital. FIs and DIs have an edge over retail investors in accessing, processing and acting upon price-sensitive information. So speculative option trading can, in effect, become a mechanism for transferring wealth from less-informed participants to better-informed and better-capitalised ones. Youngsters must understand — before they learn it the hard way — that speculative option trading is ultimately a financial game of survival of the fittest. **S Lakshminarayanan**
Vridhachalam Taluk (TN)



E20: Keep policy flexible

Rollout hasn’t fully captured the transition costs

Amarendu Nandy

In The *Decision Process* (1956), political scientist Harold Lasswell described policymaking as a set of distinct functions, from gathering intelligence and framing choices to implementation and appraisal. His core point was that success in one function cannot make up for failure in another. Charles Lindblom’s *The Science of Muddling Through* (1959) added a related lesson: since policymakers cannot foresee every consequence, implementation must leave room for learning and revision. India’s E20 rollout, and the controversy surrounding it, show why both insights matter.

THE CASE FOR BLENDING
The strategic case for ethanol blending is easy to see. PPAC data put India’s crude-import dependence at 88.6 per cent in April 2025-January 2026. Reducing that dependence lowers exposure to oil shocks and creates demand for domestic feedstocks. The government reports that blending has risen from 1.53 per cent in 2013-14 to 20 per cent in 2025-26, alongside more than ₹1.66 lakh crore in farmer payments, ₹1.97 lakh crore in forex savings, and nearly 316 lakh tonnes of crude substitution.

While the gains are real, they do not capture the full incidence of the transition. Reportedly, the mandated change to the petrol blend affected vehicles designed for an earlier fuel specification, leaving existing owners to bear the adjustment cost. With E0 barely available at pumps, owners with older vehicles had little option but to accept the mileage penalty or component-related costs associated with E20. Those costs were not part of the calculation when the vehicles were purchased. Effectively, the policy changed the return on an asset after the investment had already been made.

The government, it turns out, had not *a priori* established how large that cost was. On July 27 in the Rajya Sabha, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas acknowledged that the Ministry of Heavy Industries had not assessed what share of the existing fleet was fully E20-compatible. It also accepted that non-compatible vehicles could face a 3-5 per cent drop in fuel economy. This implies that the transition rolled ahead without any clear estimate of how widely those costs might fall.

That blind spot partly reflects



SHIFT. Owners of older vehicles must get sufficient time to adjust

the way the blending target came to define success. A 20 per cent blending goal gave distilleries, oil companies and vehicle manufacturers the confidence to invest. But as those investments were made and supply chains adjusted, changing course appears to have become harder. As progress is judged mainly by whether blending targets are met, questions such as fleet readiness and consumer costs have received less attention. The target appears to have driven the policy instead of serving it.

Lasswell’s emphasis on appraisal and Lindblom’s emphasis on learning become relevant here. Policymakers cannot be expected to foresee every consequence before a policy is introduced, but evidence that emerges during implementation should shape what happens next. Questions about mileage, vehicle compatibility, and warranties are part of that evidence. Dismissing them as “myths” or “fear mongering” risks ignoring information on how the transition has affected users.

International evidence suggests that policy credibility does not require policy irreversibility. When Britain introduced E10, it retained E5 as a protection grade, provided a vehicle-compatibility checker and built in a review. India need not copy that model, but the principle is useful. Environmental performance should also be assessed through lifecycle emissions, water use, and feedstock choice, rather than blending volumes alone.

Policy scholarship has long reminded us that a policy is not complete once adopted. Revising an instrument in the light of experience is part of governing, not an admission of retreat. The concerns raised by E20 should therefore be treated as feedback that the original design did not adequately incorporate.

The writer is Associate Professor in the Economics & Public Policy Area at IIM Ranchi. Views are personal

THE WIDER ANGLE.



PARAN BALAKRISHNAN

There’s a view circulating in Iran that there’s little point in striking a deal with the US while Donald Trump is president. That’s because he can change the terms at the very last minute and, even then, can’t be relied upon to honour them. Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney just got a lesson in why that argument resonates far beyond Tehran. Only days ago, Canada and the US appeared close to a trade pact. Trump had declared “subject to the finalization of documents (we) have a DEAL.” Ottawa said “substantial progress” had been made. Then, at the eleventh hour, the talks collapsed.

Carney ordered his negotiators home, saying the US had introduced last-minute “unfair” and “uneconomic” conditions. He also questioned whether any agreement with Washington could be relied upon, declaring “sometimes its signature is written in pencil.”

The breakdown matters because Canada is hardly an American adversary. The neighbours have one of the world’s deepest trading relationships and have spent decades building an extraordinarily integrated North American economy. Yet now, Carney says Canada is at economic war with the US. “We were attacked,” and when a country is attacked, “you’re at war”

Washington has slapped 50 per cent tariffs on \$20 billion worth of Canadian goods, while Canada declared it would retaliate dollar-for-dollar.

SOVEREIGNTY ISSUES
What makes the Canadian experience particularly disturbing is what happened in the talks’ final stages. According to Carney, the US raised demands touching issues Ottawa regarded not merely as questions of trade but of Canadian sovereignty.

One concerned language and culture. Canada is bilingual, and protecting French, particularly in Quebec, is part of the fundamental political and constitutional fabric. Language requirements irritate some foreign businesses, which complain about the extra costs. But Carney said, “We weren’t prepared to compromise on the protection of the French language and our culture.”



POOL REUTERS VI

The art of no deal

US says India trade pact is imminent — but so was Canada’s

Equally explosive were American attempts to restrict Canada’s ability to strike foreign trade agreements. Carney has spent much of his premiership seeking to reduce Canada’s overwhelming US market dependence. Giving Washington a veto over those relationships would have been a blow to Canadian sovereignty. The US also reportedly sought right of first refusal preferential access to Canada’s immense critical minerals resources.

Taken individually, Washington might describe each of these as part of a hard commercial negotiation. Taken together, Canadians saw something very different: an attempt by the vastly larger neighbour to acquire leverage over Canadian policy.

Carney said the Americans had “asked too much”.

Why would Washington allow

negotiations that appeared near completion to collapse over demands introduced at the last moment? One theory is personal animosity played a role – that Trump doesn’t like Carney and never wanted a deal. Trump has repeatedly declared Canada should become America’s 51st state.. After the talks disintegrated, he declared Canada wanted “the benefits of being a state, without being one”.

Whatever Washington’s motives, it’s united Canadians as never before. Provincial premiers have rallied behind Carney, and the dispute has revived the “Team Canada” approach that Ottawa has cultivated throughout the trade confrontation. It also breathed new life into the “buy Canadian” campaign. Even earlier, US liquor had disappeared from Canadian shelves, and Canadians were avoiding US travel.

INDIA’S APPROACH
The extraordinary question is how the US and Canada, which were among the closest economic partners on the planet, reached this point. And that brings us to India. New Delhi should study the Canadian experience extremely carefully.

India was first out of the starting gate to negotiate a US trade deal. At various

stages, both sides have said an accord was near only for the talks to lose momentum.

Over the weekend, US Ambassador Sergio Gor said most major elements have now been agreed “in principle”, and what remains is working out the legal and technical language. Gor also announced Secretary of State Marco Rubio would return to India in October for a second time this year, portraying this as proof of the weight Washington attaches to its India ties.

That’s encouraging. But only days before the Canada-US negotiations collapsed, Trump had declared the trade deal all but done.

A US trade agreement could be immensely valuable. But New Delhi shouldn’t assume agreement “in principle” means the tough part is over. Every clause matters. Provisions buried in technical language may have consequences for India’s agricultural policy, its autonomy, its dealings with Russia, its digital economy or its freedom to negotiate agreements with other countries.

Canada thought it was approaching the finish line, but then Washington moved the line. New Delhi will have to watch carefully to make sure the US doesn’t try the same thing.

thehindubusinessline. TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

August 26, 2006

Cap on wheat, pulses stock

In a bid to curtail spiralling prices of wheat and pulses, the Union Government has allowed the State Governments to enforce restrictions on stock limits, licensing requirements and movement of these two commodities. The restoration of the powers of States to clamp these restrictions under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955 (ECA) is valid for a period of six months.

Biggies line up for Railways call centres

Biggies from the IT and telecom industry, including Airtel, BSNL, Reliance Infocomm, Tata Teleservices, HP, Wipro and IBM, are eyeing the Indian Railways call centre operations, which would be outsourced. The call centre would have to provide basic train enquiry services at the cost of a local call for passengers calling from anywhere in the country.

Govt to issue oil bonds for ₹14,150 cr soon

The Government will issue the first tranche of oil bonds worth ₹14,150 crore out of a total of ₹28,300 crore to State-owned oil marketing companies by the month-end. The bonds are to compensate the companies for selling petroleum products below cost price.

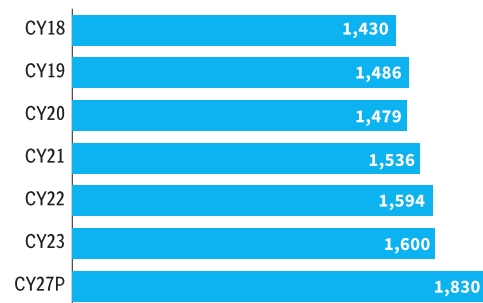
STATISTALK.

Compiled **Dhuraivel Gunasekaran** | Graphic **Visweswaran V**

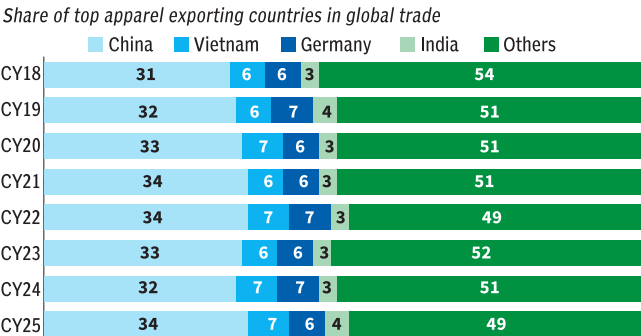
The great textile reset: Can India seize the opportunity?

The global textile industry is undergoing a fundamental shift as brands and retailers reduce their dependence on China and diversify sourcing networks, according to a Nuvama report. The global textile market has expanded steadily and is projected to approach \$1.8 trillion by CY27. China’s share of global apparel exports has declined steadily, while Vietnam, Bangladesh and other Asian suppliers have gained ground. India, meanwhile, retains a leading position in global home-textile exports. As retailers diversify sourcing beyond China, India’s established strengths in bedding and furnishings offer immediate growth opportunities. Future growth, however, will hinge on export competitiveness and the ability to capitalise on the ongoing global supply-chain diversification.

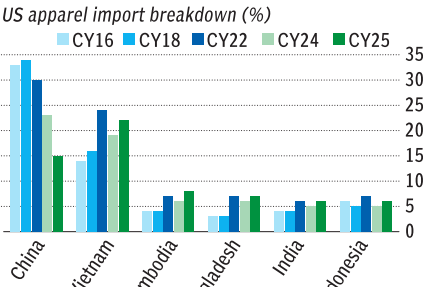
Global textile market size (\$ billion): A \$1.8 trillion opportunity



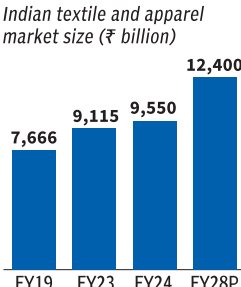
India’s share stuck at 4%, a missed opportunity



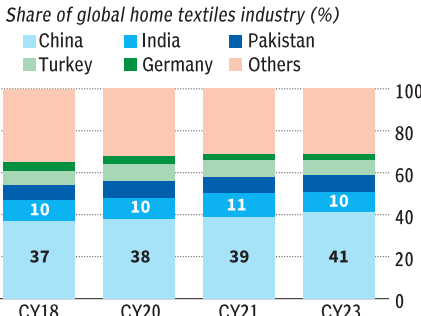
China loses share, leaving room for India to grow



India’s textile industry is growing — but exports need to accelerate

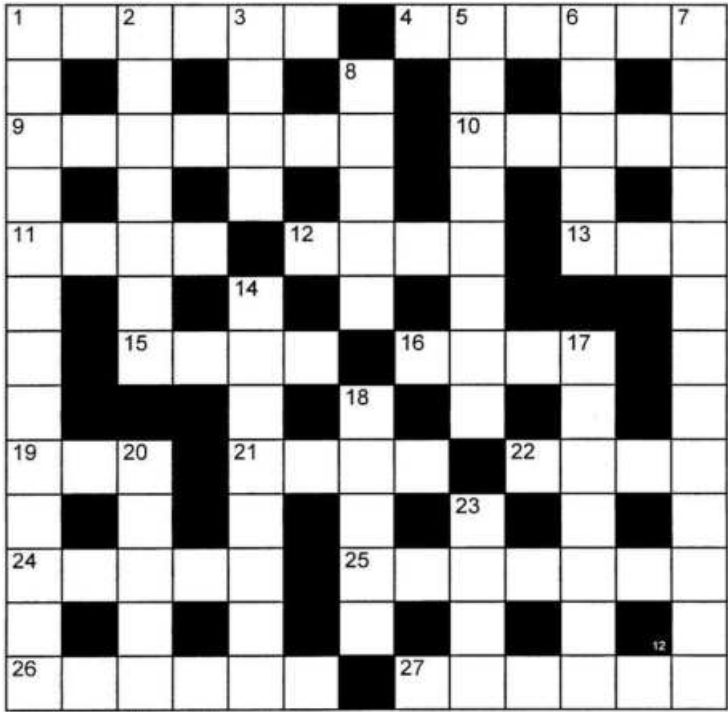


India remains a key player in global home textiles



Source: Nuvama

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2722



EASY

ACROSS

- Treat with contempt (6)
- Sacredly obscure (6)
- Thin water-biscuit (7)
- Farewell (5)
- Catch sight of, see at a distance (4)
- Aquatic bird (4)
- Outfit (3)
- Appear indistinctly, as out of the mist (4)
- Cut short, humiliate (4)
- Writing medium (3)
- Water-filled castle ditch (4)
- Dry sherry (4)
- Ring on target next to bull (5)
- Sleep-inducing drugs (7)
- Warship petty officers (6)
- One supporting artistic enterprise (6)

DOWN

- Fact of being beyond belief (13)
- Knife for dissection (7)
- Carmine (4)
- Having earnest desire (8)
- A stratagem, artifice (5)
- Out-of-town relative (7,6)
- Crease the brow in anger (5)
- Traffic, trade (8)
- Raised bubble of skin (7)
- An open railway truck (5)
- A Japanese martial art (5)
- Top soprano (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- In this month, almost the whole of last month was an affront (6)
- Magic? My wand has lost its end (6)
- Biscuit that may have a motto in it (7)
- After a start, one may be due a final word (5)
- Catch sight of an English secret agent (4)
- It isn’t enough to show off, as this bird shows (4)
- Pieces to be made up into a small furry animal (3)
- Part of an oar that will be useful to a weaver (4)
- It is a rebuff for such a nose to be blunt (4)
- With which one may draw fluid from a cuttlefish (3)
- For an instant at the end it surrounds the castle (4)
- If no mixture is made, the sherry will be dry (4)
- QC’s bar is on-target (5)
- Drugs that work on one with a blend of teas (7)
- They may have been farmers, beefeaters or signallers (6)
- One with a protégé has no part to play (6)

DOWN

- Licit in Derby, one might find it impossible to believe (13)
- Sell cap in order for it to make cuts (7)
- A stretch of water coloured red (4)
- May have a longing for any reign to be overthrown (8)
- Some cards may be taken by stratagem (5)
- A rural relative is one unused to the ways of town (7,6)
- Fellow has somehow worn a look of displeasure (5)
- Trade to have communication with (8)
- Bachelor surgeon from the past found it raised on the skin (7)
- Now arranging to hold silver in the truck (5)
- Martial art that will finish in a knockout (5)
- Prima donna who was keen to turn up (4)

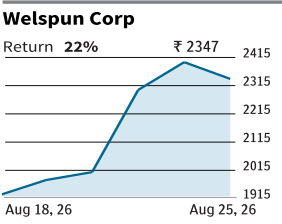
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2721

ACROSS 1. Rotation 7. Meant 8. Summons 9. Tendril 10. Girl 12. Revised 14. Makings 17. Esse 18. Goddess 21. Trouble 22. Trait 23. Smugness

DOWN 1. Resign 2. Tamarisk 3. Troy 4. Oyster 5. Pair 6. Stolid 7. Miniver 11. Contest 13. Sensible 14. Mighty 15. System 16. Levers 19. Deal 20. Song

QUICKLY.

Welspun Corp promoters mull ₹1,417-cr share sale



Mumbai: Welspun Corp is set to witness a sizeable block deal as members of the promoter group, along with the company's Managing Director and CEO, Vipul Mathur, seeking to divest up to 63 lakh shares through an institutional placement on the Indian stock exchanges. The transaction could raise as much as ₹1,417 crore at the indicated floor price. Together, the stake sale represents around 2.4 per cent of Welspun Corp's total outstanding equity. The floor price for the transaction has been set at ₹2,250 a share, implying a discount of about 4.1 per cent to the company's closing price of ₹2,345.5 on the NSE. The deal is expected to be executed via stock exchange's block trade mechanism on August 26. OUR BUREAU

Augmont Enterprises IPO subscribed 105.78 times

Bengaluru: Augmont Enterprises IPO received stellar response, fetching 105.78 times subscription on the closing day of bidding on Tuesday, with strong demand from institutional investors. The QIB category received 226.96 times subscription, while NI portion fetched 121.47 times subscription. Retail portion was subscribed 30.98 times and the employee portion was subscribed 21.14 times. The ₹825-crore IPO has a price band of ₹750-788 per equity share, comprising of fresh issue of shares worth ₹620 crore and an offer-for-sale component worth ₹205 crore. OUR BUREAU

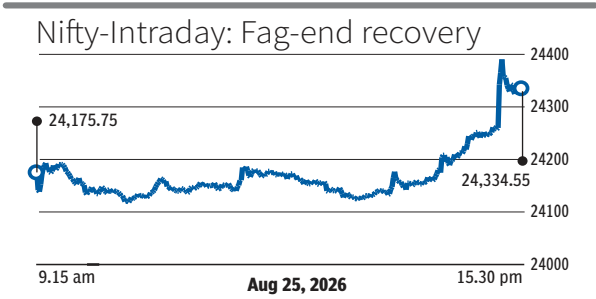
Nifty surges 115 points as CAS swings F&O expiry day close

NEW PEAK. Nifty Midcap 100 hits all-time high as Q1 results present rosy picture

Anupama Ghosh Mumbai

The benchmarks closed firmly in the green on Tuesday, the monthly derivatives expiry day on the NSE, in a session that opened under pressure from fresh US sanctions on Iran but reversed sharply in the final hour as crude oil prices fell and a newly introduced auction window delivered an unexpected swing to closing prices.

The Nifty 50 ended at 24,334, up 115.50 points, while the BSE Sensex gained 286 points to settle at 77,656. The session marked the first monthly expiry under SEBI's new Closing Auction Session (CAS) regime, introduced on August 3, under which F&O



stocks stop continuous trading at 3.15 pm and a 15-minute auction window determines the final closing price. Tuesday's auction alone pushed the Nifty up 75 points and the Sensex up 126 points from their respective 3.15 pm levels, a structural quirk that caught many participants off guard.

"Nifty staged over 200 points intra-day reversal to

close at highest level since August 14," noted Nandish Shah, Deputy Vice-President at HDFC Securities, adding that the CAS "surged nearly 75 points, which provided the fillip for the overall gains."

However, it was the Nifty Midcap 100 that stole the limelight in today's trade, as the index hit yet another all-time high and gained 0.54 per

cent to end at 64,162.90. "Q1 FY27 results indicate a clear improvement in revenue growth distribution across both Nifty 100 and Nifty Midcap 150 stocks compared with Q4FY26," said Jahol Prajapati, Equity Research Analyst, SAMCO Securities, in a recent note.

SECTOR GAINERS

On the sectoral front, Healthcare, Consumer Durable and Pharmaceuticals were the top performers. IT, Infrastructure, Media and PSU Banks also closed in the green. Energy, Metals and Private Banks were the session's laggards. Despite the positive headline close, NSE cash-market turnover fell 4 per cent versus the previous session, pointing to subdued broader participation.

SEBI slaps ₹33 cr fine on Varanium Cloud, 8 others for diversion of IPO proceeds

Press Trust of India New Delhi

SEBI on Tuesday slapped fines totalling ₹33.08 crore on SME company Varanium Cloud, its promoter Harshawardhan Hanmant Sabale, and seven others for misrepresenting the company's financials and diversion of IPO proceeds.

Besides, the regulator barred Varanium Cloud Ltd (VCL) and Sabale from the securities markets for seven years.

Further, Sabale was also restrained from being associated with any listed company or a SEBI-registered intermediary as a director for 7 years.

UNLAWFUL GAINS

In its final order, SEBI directed VCL to bring back ₹62.51 crore, which has been found to be diverted, along with 12 per cent interest from the re-

SEBI directed Sabale to disgorge ₹128.77 crore and asked the firm to bring back ₹62.51 crore found to be diverted

spective dates of debit transactions, into its accounts.

SEBI also directed Sabale to disgorge unlawful gains worth ₹128.77 crore, along with 12% interest per annum from the dates of sale of the shares till the date of deposit.

In the 155-page order, SEBI found that VCL, Sabale, Vinayak Vasant Jadhav, Mukundan Raghavan and Fahim Iunus Shaikh were involved in the misrepresentation of contents in the prospectus and non-disclosure of pending litigation in the letter of offer and the subsequent siphoning-off of public issue proceeds to the

tune of ₹18.98 crore from IPO and ₹43.53 crore from rights issue.

SEBI said Sabale had traded in the shares of VCL, and made unlawful gains to the tune of ₹128.77 crore. Similarly, SEBI observed Athos Capital Advisors and Raj Jagtani (Proprietor of BM Traders) have also made significant gains and received monies from VCL and Sabale.

"I note that Noticee no 2 (Sabale exercised complete control over the movement of IPO and rights issue proceeds and approved transfer of funds," SEBI's Whole time Member Amarjeet Singh said in the order.

A total of ₹62.51 crore (₹18.98 crore from IPO proceeds and ₹43.53 crore from rights issue proceeds) was diverted to related parties and other entities (including ₹32.73 crore to Sabale) and he granted the approvals for the transfers, the order said.

Rays of Belief, first for-profit social firm, to enter capital market with ₹125-cr IPO

Our Bureau Mumbai

A for-profit social enterprise Rays of Belief Ltd that operates under the "Mom's Belief" brand, expects its initial public offering to open on September 1.

The company said it was positioned to become India's first for-profit social enterprise to be listed on the mainboard of the Indian exchanges — BSE and NSE.

The price band has been fixed at ₹227-239 and the ₹125-crore IPO, entirely a fresh issue, closes on September 3.

Rays of Belief provides personalised intervention

plans for children with neurodevelopmental disorders (NDDs) such as autism spectrum disorder, attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder, Down Syndrome, cerebral palsy, intellectual disability, learning disabilities and global developmental delay, the note said, adding that Nitin Bindlish and Carving Futures Pte Ltd are its promoters.

Founded to address key barriers related to NDDs in the behavioural health domain, including lack of awareness, limited access, inadequate quality of care and affordability, the company develops intervention

plans to support parents and families to become co-ther-

apists in their child's developmental journey, it said.

EXPANSION PLANS

The company intends to utilise a portion of the net proceeds towards expanding its centres' network across India.

Between FY27 and FY29, it proposes to establish 128 centres in tier-1 cities, 121 in tier-2 cities and 70 in tier-3 cities, it added.

Since its start in 2018, the company has served more than 58,000 children and as on March 31, more than 2,500 active children are enrolled under various intervention plans delivered through its centres and digital platforms, it said.

Sunshine Pictures, Shankesh Jewellers each close 2% higher on debut day over IPO price

Our Bureau Bengaluru

Shares of Sunshine Pictures and Shankesh Jewellers made a modest beginning on Tuesday, but dipped below their listing prices to end with only 2 per cent gains each.

Sunshine Pictures, after opening at ₹395.90, a 10 per cent premium, closed at ₹369.20 on the NSE, against IPO price of ₹360. Shankesh Jewellers, after opening at ₹103.30, rose to ₹111, but weakened to close at ₹94.82 against the IPO price of ₹93.

Ravi Singh, Chief Research Officer, Master Cap-

ital Services, said Sunshine investors should focus on the company's ability to deliver stable earnings growth and monetise its movie and digital content portfolio.

According to Singh, stronger revenue, better collections and positive operating cash flow in upcoming results could make the stock more relevant, while the current valuation leaves less room for disappointment without such improvements.

On Shankesh Jewellers, Shivani Nyati, Head of Wealth at Swastika Investment Ltd, said she is positive on the business and its medium-term growth prospects, but advised against



QUIET LISTING. Krishnan Iyer (left), NSE, with Vipul Amrutlal Shah of Sunshine Pictures

aggressive buying immediately after listing.

DETAILS OF IPOs

The ₹282-crore IPO of film and television producer-director Vipul Shah-promoted Sunshine Pictures Ltd re-

ceived 105.81 times subscription.

The company plans to utilise up to ₹112.5 crore from the IPO proceeds to meet its long-term working capital requirements, with the remaining amount earmarked for general corporate purposes.

Meanwhile, the ₹367-crore IPO of Shankesh received 2.8 times subscription. The IPO comprised a fresh issue of up to 2.95 crore equity shares and OFS of up to 1 crore shares.

Proceeds from the IPO will be used for repayment, pre-payment of borrowings, funding working capital and general corporate purposes.

Investors need to look beyond trailing returns: HSBC MF

bl.interview

Suresh P Iyengar Mumbai



I see AI helping fund houses become more efficient, rather than simply reducing costs

KAILASH KULKARNI CEO, HSBC Asset Management India

What is your estimate on AUM growth for HSBC MF?

When HSBC acquired L&T MF, we had about ₹80,000-81,000 crore of AUM. Today, we are nearly double of that. HSBC MF previously had limited third-party distribution, while L&T brought significant strength in that area. It took about a year for distributors and investors to get accustomed to the HSBC brand, but growth has been good since then.

Our philosophy is also different. We are not a large NFO player. We launch an NFO only when we believe the product is unique, or fills a genuine gap.

Over the last 20 years, MFs have grown through market cycles, regulatory changes and various challenges. Pre-Covid, there were around 2 crore MF investors. Today, that number has crossed 6 crore, with about 6.2-6.3 crore unique investors. MFs have moved from being a push product to a pull product.

Can you give examples of products where you have followed a differentiated approach?

We were among the first to launch a pure consumption fund. We also launched an India Exports Fund before the recent focus on free-trade agreements. We defined an exporter as a company generating at least 20 per cent of its revenue from exports and built the portfolio

accordingly. More recently, in the specialised investment fund space, instead of following the conventional long-short strategy, we have adopted a different approach.

We do not take direct equity exposure; the equity component comes through arbitrage and REITs, while the balance is invested in high-quality fixed-income instruments. The objective is to deliver an FD-plus kind of return while benefiting from equity-oriented taxation.

After lacklustre returns, do you see household savings to still bet on MFs?

Yes. While the Nifty and Sensex have delivered relatively subdued returns in recent periods, many diversified mutual fund categories have delivered double-digit returns over one- and three-year periods. Investors have also shifted from traditional large-cap funds towards flexi, multi and large- and mid-cap funds.

The preference today is increasingly for diversified exposure, along with some thematic funds depending on an investor's outlook.

Are investors chasing past returns in mid- and small-cap funds?

Mature investors who have been in the market for five years or more generally maintain diversified portfolios and are less likely to rush

into pure mid-cap funds. The newer and younger investors tend to look at one-year returns and invest through apps. They will learn through experience that MFs cannot be selected simply by choosing last year's best performer. Markets and fund performance change, and investors need to look beyond trailing returns.

First-time equity investors should not look at trailing returns. If they have some risk appetite, they can start with diversified funds. Otherwise, index funds are a good starting point because investors understand what the index represents.

I strongly recommend SIPs and, more importantly, doing a risk assessment before investing in any product. Investments should be aligned with an individual's goals and risk profile.

How has your reach into smaller cities evolved?

We are present in 58 cities and have a strong distributor network in smaller markets. Distributors increasingly see mutual fund distribution as a viable business. If someone builds an AUM of ₹30-40 crore in a small city, it can generate around ₹25-30 lakh of annual earnings, which is meaningful.

Another major change is that the second generation of successful distributors now wants to enter the business. They see significant long-term potential in financial distribution.

What role can AI play in the MF industry?

AI is primarily about improving efficiency. For example, if eight analysts currently track 550 companies, AI could enable them to track 700-750 companies. It can improve MIS, research and analytics. I see AI helping fund houses become more efficient, rather than simply reducing costs. Our core philosophy remains bottom-up stock picking, consistency of performance, product uniqueness, being true to label and maintaining a long-term orientation. That will ultimately create value for investors.

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal Research

CUMMINS INDIA (BUY)

Target: ₹6,400
CMP: ₹5,230
Our recent meeting with the Cummins management suggests a strong data centre-led demand scenario for HHP gensets. This will continue to support growth despite the non-HHP segment growing at a slower pace. Volatility in RM prices suggests more price hikes will be needed in the coming months over and above the recent price hike in July 2026. We believe the growth drivers for Cummins remain: Data centres for powergen; railways, mining, defence and marine for industrial despite construction being weak; higher installed base and customised offerings in distribution; and Europe and Asia-Pacific regions for exports despite the weak West Asian market. Margins were a bit soft in Q1FY27 due to a spike in commodity prices, revenue mix and true-up of employee costs. The company intends to maintain margins at 20-21 per cent. We expect EBITDA margins of 19.8 per cent/21.3 per cent/21.5 per cent for FY27/FY28/FY29. We expect a revenue/EBITDA/PAT CAGR of 18 per cent/ 18 per cent/19 per cent over FY26-29. We trim our estimates by 4.7 per cent/2.5 per cent/2.2 per cent for FY27/FY28/FY29 to factor in the near-term pressure on margins. The stock currently trades at ₹2.8x/41.5x/35.1x P/E on FY27/FY28/FY29E EPS. We reiterate our BUY rating with a revised TP of ₹6,400 (vs ₹6,500) based on an average of 45x P/E and DCF on two-year forward estimates. Key risks include lower-than-expected demand in key segments, higher commodity prices, increased competitive intensity and a lower-than-expected recovery in exports.

Elara Securities

NYKAA (BUY)

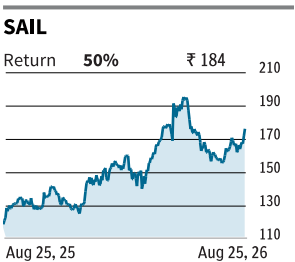
Target: ₹475
CMP: ₹332.80
Our conviction on FSN E-commerce Ventures (Nykaa) rests on the dual engines of premium user penetration and premiumisation. These underpin a durable about 25 per cent BPC GMV CAGR to FY30E. Nykaa's curated, high-AOV proposition is insulated from quick-commerce (QC) disruption (more acute for horizontal platforms). Nykaa retained leadership in online BPC (27 per cent share in FY27) despite quick commerce's rapid rise, with limited share erosion. As QC penetration plateaus, we expect Nykaa to resume share gains by FY30E, aided by its niche proposition and higher AOV, which cushions fulfilment investments and helps scale Nykaa Now. Rising premium smartphone penetration supports 25 per cent CAGR in FY26-30E. Our revenue/PAT estimates sit above consensus (FY29E) yet at the lower band of FY30 guidance. Confidence rests on multiple levers: higher platform fees offering margin upside, a high-AOV cushion supporting superior unit economics, ROE reaching 37 per cent by FY30E, unmatched by any Indian B2C internet platform and potential earnings upgrades from execution towards the upper end of guidance. Improving FCF/EBITDA conversion (59 per cent in FY26) remain ahead of global peers. We roll to FY30E and reiterate buy with higher TP of ₹475 (from ₹400).

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY'S PICK.

SAIL (₹184.20): BUY

Gurumurthy K bl. research bureau



The short-term outlook is bullish for the Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL). The stock has surged over 5 per cent so far this week breaking above a key resistance level of ₹180. This marks the end of the corrective fall that was in place since June.

A cup and handle pattern on the daily chart also strengthens the bullish case. The level of ₹180 will now act as a good support and limit the downside. The SAIL share price could rise to ₹202-₹205 from here.

Traders can buy SAIL shares now at ₹184. Accumulate on dips at ₹181. Keep the stop-loss

at ₹174. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹188 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹190 and ₹195 when the price touches ₹193 and ₹197 respectively. Exit the stock at ₹199.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24333 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
24240	24150	24355	24480	Go long on a break above 24355. Keep the stop-loss at 24305

₹724 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
721	715	727	731	Go short only below 721. Stop-loss can be kept at 723

₹1131 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1115	1080	1140	1155	Take fresh shorts below 1115 with a stop-loss at 1125

₹270 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
268	265	272	275	Go long only above 272. Stop-loss can be placed at 271

₹234 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
232	229	236	238	Go long on dips at 233. Stop-loss can be placed at 231

₹1312 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1300	1290	1320	1350	Go long on a break above 1320 with a stop-loss at 1310

₹1044 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1035	1020	1055	1070	Wait for dips. Go long at 1040 with a stop-loss at 1030

₹2288 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2260	2235	2325	2360	Take fresh longs only above 2325. Keep the stop-loss at 2315

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 115.50 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
ICICI Bank	1422.70	12.05	17.08	9.15	
Infosys	1144.00	10.73	15.31	3.60	
Reliance Ind	1317.00	10.63	20.21	7.99	
Bharti Airtel	1947.00	7.97	32.58	5.32	
State Bank	1048.00	7.68	10.79	3.89	
L&T	4119.00	7.42	28.88	4.33	
Adani Enter	1011.00	7.02	53.85	0.81	
Bajaj Finance	3180.00	6.09	32.79	2.62	
Eternal Ltd.	331.00	6.08	737.71	2.15	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1138.50	5.97	23.67	1.43	
M&M	3443.00	5.64	21.15	2.32	
IntGlobeAvi	5218.00	5.09	0.00	1.06	
Adani Ports	1702.70	4.93	29.90	1.13	
Apollo Hosp	8889.00	4.21	58.84	0.82	
Max Healthcare	1016.00	4.15	67.85	0.68	
Titan	5124.80	4.13	78.99	1.90	
WIPAC	271.40	3.58	16.85	2.35	
ITC	413.25	3.33	49.14	1.33	
Bharat Elec	11927.00	3.07	28.86	1.19	
Sun Pharma	1922.00	2.78	38.06	1.83	
TCS	2296.20	2.70	16.60	2.11	
Tech Mahindra	1599.90	2.21	30.37	0.91	
Trent Ltd.	2930.00	1.82	86.10	0.86	
Maruti Suzuki	13678.00	1.65	30.00	1.60	
NestleIndia	1479.00	1.21	74.83	0.95	
Tata Steel	186.94	1.16	20.72	1.39	
UltraTech Cement	11540.00	0.93	39.67	1.23	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	243.15	0.82	77.69	0.72	
Dy Reddys Lab	1193.50	0.47	31.29	0.65	
WIPAC	239.85	0.36	11.63	1.45	
Bajaj Finserv	2004.00	0.29	15.54	1.04	
Eicher Motors	8055.00	0.24	38.30	1.00	
Kotak Bank	401.60	0.24	19.68	2.66	
Grasim Ind	3289.60	0.13	19.67	1.11	
Tata Motors PV	314.25	-0.07	0.00	0.59	
Asian Paints	2639.00	-0.10	52.35	1.07	
DataConsumerProduct	1060.50	-0.28	63.91	0.62	
PowerGrid Corp	271.00	-0.40	15.86	1.10	
Axis Bank	1235.00	-0.63	13.75	3.18	
SBI Life	1755.00	-0.67	67.69	0.71	
Wipro	180.09	-0.72	13.43	0.44	
Hind Unilover	2024.00	-1.17	45.32	1.61	
JSW Steel	1320.30	-1.32	11.53	1.11	
HCL Tech	1315.80	-1.47	59.13	1.25	
Coal India	546.70	-1.47	24.73	0.53	
ONGC	404.00	-1.52	7.98	0.87	
Cipla	1422.00	-1.96	34.23	0.72	
Cong	230.40	-2.16	6.57	0.82	
Hindalco	1051.05	-2.36	14.40	1.37	
HDFC Bank	727.50	-5.02	13.58	1.00	

Economy continues to display strength despite global headwinds: RBI bulletin

SHOW OF RESILIENCE. Manufacturing and services activity remains robust in July; imports-exports see double-digit expansion

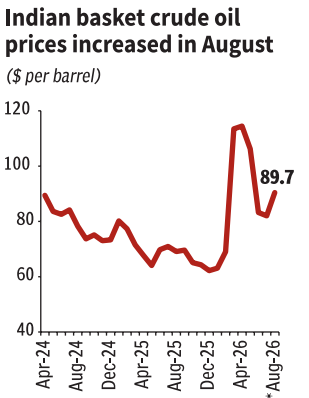
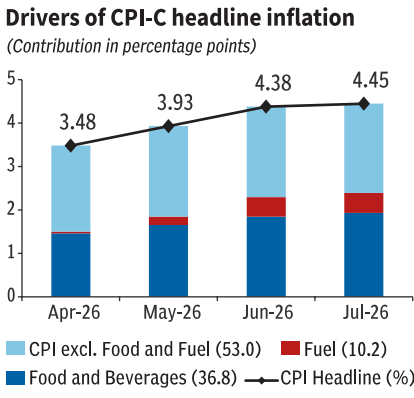
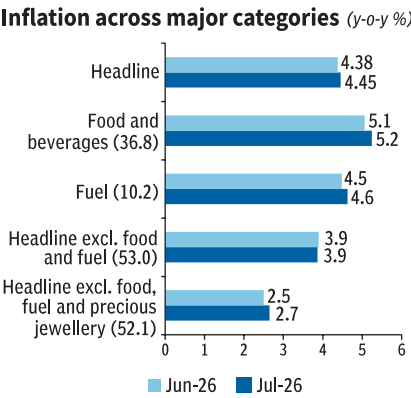
Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Indian economy continues to display strength, characterised by buoyant domestic demand, and rising manufacturing and services activity, notwithstanding headwinds arising from fragile geopolitical environment and continuing trade-related uncertainties, according to the RBI's latest monthly bulletin.

"The global economic outlook continues to be shaped by geopolitical frictions in West Asia and fresh tariffs by the US. Despite these risks to global trade and the growth-inflation matrix, India's robust macroeconomic fundamentals continue to provide cushion to the domestic economy," said RBI officials in the "State of the Economy" report published in the central bank's latest monthly bulletin.

They said the momentum

Marginal uptick in food inflation in July



Notes: 1. Figures in parentheses indicate weights in Consumer Price Index-Combined (CPI-C) (2024=100).
2. Precious jewellery includes the items 'gold/diamond/platinum jewellery' and 'silver jewellery'.
Source: National Statistics Office (NSO)

of Q1 (April-June): 2026-27 continued in July with most of the high-frequency indicators reflecting sustained manufacturing and services activity, and double-digit expansion in merchandise exports and imports.

"Domestic demand remained buoyant, as reflected

by several indicators, including vehicle and tractor sales. Petroleum product consumption growth returned to positive territory, after three straight months of contraction. Industrial production strengthened sharply in June, recording its strongest growth in nearly

two years, supported by a broad-based acceleration in manufacturing. The services sector also exhibited resilience," the officials said.

EXPORT GROWTH

Further, both merchandise exports and imports grew strongly (at 19.6 per cent to

\$44.2 billion and 17.5 per cent to 76.2 billion, year-on-year or y-o-y respectively) in July 2026 with exports growing at a four month high (in 2026-27 so far).

Export growth was led by petroleum products, electronic goods and engineering products. Merchandise

trade deficit widened in July to \$32 billion, both sequentially and on a y-o-y basis, reflecting a widening of deficit in electronic goods.

The officials said the recovery in South-West Monsoon in July helped in kharif sowing reaching closer to normal acreage, partly mitigating some of the risks to the agriculture sector.

INFLATION EDGES UP

While headline CPI inflation edged up above the target (to 4.45 per cent in July 2026 from 4.38 per cent in June, driven primarily by food prices), the officials observed that it was primarily on account of supply side pressures.

Stable core inflation reaffirmed the lower pass-through of cost pressures. The price of the Indian basket crude oil increased to \$89.7 per barrel in August (till 20th), higher than the average price recorded in both June and July.

NRI deposit inflows dip 22% to \$2.8 billion in April-June of FY27

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Non-resident deposits - inflows

(in \$ billion)

	April - June		y-o-y %
	2025	2026	
FCNR(B)	0.8	1.7	123
NR(E)	2	0.14	-93
NRO	0.8	0.9	12.5
Total NRI deposits	3.6	2.8	-22.2

FCNR(B) - Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank); NR(E) - Non-Resident (External); NRO - Non-Resident Ordinary

FCNR(B) deposits to encourage foreign currency inflows into India.

Under the framework, RBI provided banks with a special forex swap facility for eligible fresh FCNR(B) deposits helping banks to offer more competitive deposit rates. \$72.85 billion of foreign exchange has been generated via FCNR(B) deposits, external commercial borrowings (ECBs) and overseas foreign currency borrowings (OFCBs) under this facility as on August 21.

SPECIAL FOREX SWAP

Experts told *businessline* that the RBI's special forex swap window also allows NRIs to move funds from NRE accounts to FCNR(B) and it is likely that it could have also been the case in the month of June 2026.

NRE deposits are bank accounts held in India by NRIs to deposit and manage money earned in foreign countries.

'Fresh deposit and lending rates have hardened in recent months'

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Fresh deposit and lending rates have hardened in recent months with the rising credit demand, according to the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI's) latest monthly bulletin.

The weighted average domestic term deposit rate (WADTDR) on fresh deposits rose by 16 basis points

(bps) in June 2026 against a 4 bps increase in May 2026. One basis point is equal to 0.01 per cent.

LOANS INCREASED

The weighted average lending rate (WALR) on fresh rupee loans increased by 2 bps in June 2026 against a 1 bp increase in May 2026, according to the data in the bulletin.

However, the one-year marginal cost of funds-based

lending rate (MCLR) declined by 15 bps in June 2026 against an increase of 10 bps in May 2026.

In his last monetary policy statement, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra observed that the transmission (of the cumulative 125 basis points repo rate cuts during the current easing cycle: February 2026 to June 2026 period) in the credit market moderated during May-June with hardening of deposit and

lending rates. Nevertheless, credit growth continues to remain robust and broad-based across sectors.

DEPOSIT GROWTH

Scheduled commercial banks' credit and deposit growth stood at 19.3 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) and 15.4 per cent y-o-y respectively, as on July 31, 2026, compared to 18.6 per cent y-o-y and 13.3 per cent y-o-y respectively, as on June 30,

2026. Sector-wise data indicates buoyant credit flows to retail and services sector.

Industrial credit strengthened further, aided by sustained credit growth in MSMEs and pickup in credit to large industries.

Agricultural credit grew at a steady pace.

BANK PERFORMANCE

Across bank groups, private sector banks recorded stronger pass-through to

lending rates than public sector banks, while later exhibited relatively higher transmission to deposit rates during the current easing cycle, RBI officials said in the "State of the Economy" report in the bulletin.

Flow of financial resources to commercial sector increases to ₹10.65 lakh cr in April-July

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The total flow of financial resources to the commercial sector in the first four months of the current financial year at ₹10.65 lakh crore soared 2.38 times against ₹4.48 lakh crore in the year ago period, according to RBI data. Within this, the flow of non-food credit shot up about 9.16 times to ₹6.69 lakh crore against ₹73,000 crore in the year-ago period.

Further, the flow of financial resources from non-bank sources, comprising domestic and foreign sources, was up 5.31 per cent y-o-y at ₹3.96 lakh crore (₹3.76 lakh crore in the year-ago period).

CREDIT GROWTH

The total flow of financial resources to the commercial

RBI officials noted that bank credit continued to record robust growth across major sectors in June 2026

sector increased in 2026-27 so far (up to July 31), driven by a pickup in non-food bank credit and rise in foreign direct investment (FDI to India is on a net basis — gross inflows adjusted for repatriation/disinvestment) to India, the RBI said in its latest monthly bulletin.

In the "State of the Economy" report, RBI officials noted that credit growth continued to remain healthy in July. The recent deposit mobilisation by scheduled commercial banks' (SCBs) helped the incremental

credit-deposit ratio to moderate.

SCBs' credit and deposit growth stood at 19.3 per cent y-o-y and 15.4 per cent y-o-y respectively, as on July 31, 2026, compared to 18.6 per cent y-o-y and 13.3 per cent y-o-y respectively, as on June 30, 2026.

RBI officials noted that bank credit continued to record robust growth across major sectors in June 2026. Credit to the agriculture sector accelerated, and industrial credit growth sustained its momentum aided by an expansion in credit to the large industries.

Credit flow to the services sector also strengthened, driven by non-banking financial companies, trade and commercial real estate. Personal loans picked up in June, supported by housing loans and loans against gold jewellery.

Three major Indian banks generate over \$1.85 billion in offshore bonds

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Three major Indian banks — Axis Bank, Kotak Mahindra Bank and Union Bank of India — made significant moves in the international debt markets on Monday and Tuesday, collectively involving \$1.85 billion in offshore bond activity, even as their shares traded mixed on the NSE on Tuesday.

BANK PERFORMANCE

Axis Bank said it will redeem its \$600 million 4.1 per cent Additional Tier 1 (AT1) notes in full on September 8, 2026, the First Call Date, at par or 100 per cent of the principal, plus accrued and unpaid interest.

The bank's shares closed at ₹1,235 on Tuesday, down 0.08 per cent, with a market capitalisation of approximately ₹3.84 lakh crore.

Kotak Mahindra Bank allotted \$650 million in 5.478 per cent senior unsecured notes due August 24, 2031, under its \$1 billion Euro Medium Term Note programme, on August 24.

The five-year notes, rated BBB by S&P Global Ratings and issued under Regulation S of the US Securities Act of 1933, will be listed on India International Exchange (IFSC) Limited and NSE IFSC Limited.

Coupon payments are scheduled semi-annually on February 24 and August 24 each year, with principal redeemable at par on maturity.

The bank's stock closed largely flat at ₹401.60, up 0.04 per cent, valuing the bank at around ₹3.99 lakh crore on NSE.

Union Bank of India disclosed the issuance of a dual-tranche \$600 million offering of USD-denomin-

ated senior unsecured notes through its DIFC Branch in Dubai, filed with exchanges on August 24 and 25.

The offering comprises two tranches of \$300 million each, a three-year note maturing August 28, 2029, carrying a coupon of 5.230 per cent, and a five-year note maturing August 28, 2031, at 5.417 per cent, both paying semi-annually from February 28, 2027.

Union Bank shares surged 1.84 per cent to close at ₹186.98, making it the day's standout performer among the three, with a market cap of approximately ₹1.43 lakh crore.

The flurry of offshore activity reflects continued appetite among Indian banks for international capital markets to diversify funding, manage liability profiles, and support growth, even as domestic equity markets remain range-bound.

THE LAKSHMI MILLS COMPANY LIMITED
Regd. Office: 686, Avانشi Road,
Pappanaickenpalayam, Coimbatore - 641 037.
Phone : 91- 0422 - 2245461 to 2245465, 4333700
E-mail: secretarial@lakshmillsmills.com | Web : www.lakshmillsmills.com
CIN: L17111TZ1910PLC000093

NOTICE TO SHAREHOLDERS
Single Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation of Physical Securities

Pursuant to SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, shareholders are hereby informed that a Special Window facility has been opened for a period of one year, from February 5, 2026 to February 4, 2027, for fresh lodgement and also for such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and were rejected, returned or not attended due to deficiencies in documents, process or otherwise, for the transfer and dematerialisation of physical securities which were sold / purchased prior to April 1, 2019. The shares lodged for transfer will be processed only in demat mode and shall be subject to lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Shareholders may avail this opportunity by submitting the requisite documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agents: M/s. MUFG Intime India Private Ltd., "Surya", 35, Mayflower Avenue, Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road, Coimbatore - 641028. Phone: +91 422 4958995 / 2539835-836. Email: helpdesk@in.mmps.mufg.com.

Place : Coimbatore For The Lakshmi Mills Company Limited
Date : 25.8.2026 **N. Singaravel**
Company Secretary

THE RAMCO CEMENTS LIMITED
Registered Office:
"Ramamandiram", Rajapalayam-626 117, Tamil Nadu.
Corporate Office: "Auras Corporate Centre", 5th Floor,
No:98-A, Dr.Radhakrishnan Road, Mylapore, Chennai-600004.
Ph.: 044-28478666 E-Mail: investorrelations@ramcocements.co.in
CIN : L26941TN1957PLC003566; Website : www.ramcocements.in

"UNCLAIMED DIVIDENDS"

In accordance with Section 124(5) of the Companies Act, 2013, the dividends which were not claimed for a period of 7 years or more are liable to be transferred by the Company to Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (IEPFA), Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India. The Company has been conducting various campaigns to remind the shareholders to claim the dividend in time. Accordingly, the Company has been regularly reminding its shareholders, through publication of notice in widely circulated newspapers, social media platforms and by sending of individual letters to their last known address.

In case any dividend remains unclaimed relating to the past years, shareholders are requested to claim the same from the Company and can send their requests to
The Secretarial Department,
The Ramco Cements Limited,
"Auras Corporate Centre", 5th Floor,
98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Road,
Mylapore, Chennai – 600 004, Tamil Nadu.

For prompt receipt of dividend, the Company requests the shareholders who hold shares in physical form, to update correct bank account particulars, viz. Name of the Bank and Branch, Account Number, IFS Code, MICR Number, etc.

For shareholders, who hold shares in dematerialised form, the same may please be done with the depository participant, wherein they maintain their demat account.

For THE RAMCO CEMENTS LIMITED,
Chennai
26-08-2026 **K.SELVANAYAGAM,**
SECRETARY.

Paradeep Phosphates Limited
CIN: L20122OR1981PLC001020
Registered Office: 5th Floor, Orissa State Handloom Weavers' Co-Operative Building, Pandit J N Marg, Bhubaneswar – 751 001 Tel: 0674 666 6100.
Corporate Office: Adventz Centre, 3rd Floor, No. 28, Union Street, Off Cubbon Road, Bengaluru – 560001.
Tel: 080 4681 2500/555 **E-mail:** cs.ppl@adventz.com **Website:** www.paradeepphosphates.com

NOTICE OF THE 44th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND E-VOTING INFORMATION

NOTICE is hereby given that the 44th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Members of the Company will be held on **Thursday, September 17, 2026 at 3.00 P.M.**, through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 read with General Circular dated 22.09.2025 read with circulars issued earlier on the subject by Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars") and Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI Listing Regulations"), to transact the businesses as set out in the notice of AGM.

In pursuance of the MCA Circulars & SEBI Listing Regulations, notice of the AGM and Annual report of the Company for the Financial Year 2025-26 have been sent electronically through email on Tuesday, August 25, 2026 to those members whose email addresses are registered with the Company or MUFG Intime India Private Limited (Registrar and Share Transfer Agent or "RTA" of the Company) or Depositories / Depository Participant(s). These documents are also available on the Company's website at www.paradeepphosphates.com and on the websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. National Stock Exchange of India Ltd and BSE Limited at www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com respectively. Additionally, a copy of the same is also available on the website of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") at www.evotingindia.com.

A letter providing the web-link for accessing the Annual Report has been sent to those members who have not registered their e-mail address with the Company or RTA or the Depositories / Depository Participants.

The Company is providing remote e-voting facility ("remote e-voting") to all its Members to cast their votes on all resolutions in respect of the businesses to be transacted at the 44th AGM. The Company has engaged Central Depositories Services (India) Limited (CDSL) for providing remote e-voting facility and the facility of e-Voting to the members participating in the AGM through VC/OAVM. The process and manner of remote e-Voting, attending AGM through VC/OAVM and e-Voting at AGM have been provided in the notice of AGM.

The Members are hereby informed that:

- Date of completion of dispatch of notice by email: Tuesday, August 25, 2026.
- All the businesses as set out in the Notice of the 44th AGM may be transacted through voting by electronic means.
- The remote e-voting shall commence on **September 14, 2026 at 10.00 AM.**
- The remote e-voting shall end on **September 16, 2026 at 5.00 PM.**
- The cut-off date for the purpose of remote e-voting is **September 10, 2026.**
- Any person, who acquires shares and becomes Member of the Company after dispatch of the Notice and holds shares on as on the cut-off date, may obtain copy of the notice and Annual Report by sending a request to the Company in writing or by sending email to cs.ppl@adventz.com or the same can be downloaded from the Company's website www.paradeepphosphates.com.
- Members are further informed that:
 - Remote e-voting shall not be allowed beyond 5.00 PM on September 16, 2026.
 - Only those shareholders, who are present in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility and have not casted their vote on the Resolutions through remote e-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system available during the AGM.
 - A Member may participate in the Annual General Meeting even after exercising the right to vote through remote e-voting but shall not be allowed to vote again during the meeting.
 - A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in the Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date i.e. September 10, 2026, only shall be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-voting as well as e-voting during the AGM.
- In case you have any queries or issues regarding e-voting, you may refer to Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and e-voting manual available at www.evotingindia.com under "Help" section or e-mail to helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com the e-voting Helpdesk, addressing Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Sr. Manager, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futrex, Mafatal Mill Compounds, N.M.Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai – 400013 or call on 1800 21 09911. Individual Shareholders holding securities in Demat mode with NSDL facing any technical issue in login can contact NSDL helpdesk by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in or call at toll free no.: 1800 1020 990 and 1800 22 44 30.

Members may register/update their email address and/or bank account details, by following the procedure mentioned below:

- For members holding shares in physical form: Please send duly filled Schedule Form, ISR-1 (available on the website of the Company at <https://www.paradeepphosphates.com/investors/kyc-compliance>) along with requisite documents to the RTA of the Company i.e., MUFG Intime India Private Limited (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited), Unit: Paradeep Phosphates Limited, C-101, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai – 400 083.
- For members holding shares in demat form: Please register/update your email address and/or bank account details through your depository participant(s).

The members may note that, w.e.f. April 01, 2024, any payment including dividend is to be paid in electronic mode only. Accordingly, members are requested to update their KYC and to notify change in bank account details, if any by following the procedure mentioned above.

Place : Bengaluru For Paradeep Phosphates Limited
Date : August 25, 2026 **Sachin Patil**
Company Secretary

QUICKLY.

Top Tiger Analytics role
for Prakash Arunachalam



Chennai: Tiger Analytics, a provider of AI & advanced analytics consulting services, has appointed Prakash Arunachalam as its Global Head of Operations. In this role, Arunachalam will be responsible for increased holistic operational efficiency and agility to enable sustained business growth and strengthen profitability.

Airbound raises \$37 m for
drone delivery network

Bengaluru: Aerospace start-up Airbound has raised \$37 million in a Series A round led by Greenoaks, with participation from investors including DoorDash, Lachy Groom, Lightspeed and Humba Ventures to build a drone delivery network. Since its launch, Airbound has raised nearly \$50 million. The funding will be used to accelerate engineering, manufacturing and go-to-market initiatives.

H-1B fee hike:
Nasscom says visa
reliance down

Press Trust of India

IT industry body Nasscom on Tuesday said the proposed \$1,03,265 increase in H-1B visa fees must be viewed in the context of the programme's original purpose of addressing skill shortages in the US, noting that Indian technology firms have already significantly reduced their reliance on such visas.

It noted that Indian companies had steadily expanded local hiring in the US over the past five years.

"The H-1B visa programme has long served an important purpose in addressing short-term skill gaps in the US. It is also important to recognise that, over the past 5 years, the number of H-1B employees of Indian technology companies operating has reduced significantly, as companies have steadily expanded local hiring," Nasscom said.

A proposed increase in visa fees must, therefore, it said, be viewed in the context of the programme's original purpose of enabling access to temporary skills where there is a shortage in the US.

The industry body further pointed out that the Indian technology sector has invested more than \$1.1 billion to strengthen the STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) pipeline in the US.

‘Public sector banks more
efficient than pvt lenders’

FARING BETTER. Efficiency of PSBs improved to 93.12% in FY26 from 72.46% in FY20: EAC-PM

Shishir Sinha

Contrary to popular perception, a working paper by the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) has said that efficiency of public sector banks (PSBs) is much better than that of private banks and foreign banks (FBs).

The paper, authored by Soumya Kanti Ghosh, part-time member, EAC-PM and Group Chief Economic Advisor at State Bank of India and Tapas Kumar Parida, economist at SBI studied 47 banks for the period FY15 to FY26 and employed data envelopment analysis to calculate efficiency and productivity of the banks. It studied 12 PSBs, 21 private sector banks and 14 FBs. These banks cover more than 95 per cent of the assets of the banking system.

Efficiency has been measured between 0 and 1 and the range is expressed in percentage terms.

The paper found that PSBs



LEADING FROM THE FRONT. Among PSBs, SBI performed relatively better and scored 97.49 per cent during the full sample period FY15-FY26

efficiency improved to 93.12 per cent in FY26 from 72.46 per cent in FY20, citing subsequent capital infusion and technological upgradation in select PSBs as key reasons for improvement.

"PSBs are relatively more efficient than private banks except in FY19-FY22, which may be due to merger and rationalisation of business, branches, and employees," the paper said.

BIG IMPROVEMENT

Further, private sector banks recorded improvement to over 86 per cent in FY26 from around 78 per cent in

FY20. Foreign banks' efficiency remained 83-85 per cent during FY20 to FY26. "It is interesting to know that the performance of PSBs is in a better position compared to private banks, especially during the last 3 years, i.e., FY24 to FY26," the paper said.

Among PSBs, SBI performs relatively better and scored 97.49 per cent during the full sample period FY15-FY26, followed by Bank of Maharashtra at 90.49 per cent. Among the private banks, HDFC Bank has scored 97.54 per cent followed by IDBI Bank at 96.51

GST notice must contain
clear grounds for fraud or
suppression, says SC

Shishir Sinha

The Supreme Court has ruled that a show cause notice (SCN) under Section 74 of the CGST Act to an assessee must contain clear grounds for fraud or suppression, rather than simply saying that there is doubt about fraud or suppression of facts.

Experts said that the decision provides a strong ground for challenge in cases where notices merely reproduce statutory language without disclosing the basis for alleging fraud or suppression.

APPEAL DISPOSING

Disposing of an appeal against a Madhya Pradesh High Court ruling, the top court said a bare reading of the notice would indicate that but for a bland statement of "fraud or concealment of facts", nothing is stated as to how fraud was inferred or concealment of facts were detected.

In fact, the "or" employed indicates that even the assessing officer was not sure that the assessment was proceeded by reason of fraud or on the ground of concealment of facts. "What is required for the extended time to be applied are the allegations, which lead to the inference of a fraud or the concealment as attempted by



the assessee resulting in suppression of facts, should emanate from the notice itself," a Division Bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said in its order.

According to the Bench, it cannot be a mechanical use of the words "fraud, wilful misstatement or suppression of facts" without listing out the aspects which persuades the assessing officer to conclude that the assessee has employed either of these surreptitious devices. It also directed the tax department to desist from taking any further proceedings in pursuance of the SCN challenged before the High Court, which has now been set aside.

Commenting on the ruling, Harpreet Singh, Partner at Deloitte, said that the judgment reinforces that allegations of fraud, wilful misstatement or suppression cannot be made in a routine or mechanical manner and must be supported by specific factual assertions in the SCN itself.

Avaada in deal
to develop green
industrial campus

Rishi Ranjan Kala

Avaada Group said on Tuesday it has signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the Haryana Enterprises Promotion Centre (HEPC) to facilitate the development of a 300-acre Zero-CBAM Green Industrial Campus in Hisar.

The proposed investment is around ₹10,000 crore and has the potential to generate more than 5,000 employment opportunities. The campus is envisioned as a next-generation green industrial ecosystem, powered by reliable, traceable and round-the-clock renewable energy.

SUPPORT INDUSTRIES

It is designed to support industries seeking to decarbonise their operations, strengthen energy security and enhance their readiness for evolving global carbon and sustainability requirements, including the European Union's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM), it added.

Vineet Mittal, Chairman of Avaada Group, said, "The campus will bring together reliable, traceable and round-the-clock renewable energy with industrial infrastructure designed to support low-carbon and CBAM-ready manufacturing."

Haryana will facilitate the development as a State-supported green industrial/Zero-CBAM Industrial Park.

Rupee makes strong recovery; outlook weak

Akhil Nallamathu

The rupee made a sharp recovery in the final trading hours of Tuesday after having been stable for a week. The domestic currency closed at 95.41 on Tuesday, compared with 95.68 a week ago.

Crude oil price declining over 2 per cent on Tuesday aided the rupee to recover.

Brent crude oil price currently at \$89.50/barrel, is down nearly 5 per cent so far this week after gaining 6.6 per cent last week.

WEEKLY RUPEE
VIEW.

However, uncertainty surrounding the Strait of Hormuz continues to pose an upside risk to oil prices.

POSITIVE FLOW

Foreign flows remained positive.

According to NSDL data, net FPI inflows stood at about \$693 million over the past week, taking the cumulative inflows in August so far to around \$2.4 billion.

Dollar inflows have received an additional boost from the special USD-INR swap facility linked to FCNR (B) deposits, with inflows amounting to around \$65 billion ahead of August 31, the revised deadline.

Meanwhile, India's foreign exchange reserves jumped nearly \$10 billion in the week ended August 14 to \$716.9 billion, indicating

TN govt defends Parandur airport
decision, seeks alternative site

Our Bureau

The Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce Department's Policy Note for 2026-27, tabled in Tamil Nadu Assembly on Tuesday, noted that the government would identify alternative sites for a greenfield international airport near Chennai in consultation with experts.

Feasibility studies for the identified sites will be undertaken through the Airports Authority of India (AAI), following which the State government will take necessary action based on the recommendations, the policy note said.

It also outlined plans to expand the existing Chennai airport while the search for a new greenfield airport site is undertaken.

NEW TERMINAL

"AAI has proposed establishing a new passenger terminal on the north-western side of Chennai airport. It has sought the State government's support and necessary clearances for constructing an elevated road connecting the new terminal with the National Highway. The Tamil Nadu government will provide the necessary



Tamil Nadu Industries Minister S Keerthana

support to AAI for implementing the expansion," according to the policy note.

While tabling the policy note in the Assembly, the government also defended its decision to abandon the proposed ₹27,000 crore greenfield airport at Parandur, with Industries Minister S Keerthana assuring the Assembly that land acquisition for an alternative airport would not come at the cost of agriculturists' livelihoods.

Participating in a debate on the Parandur airport project, Keerthana also said the State's industrial land acquisition agency SIPCOT would follow a similar approach while acquiring land for industrial projects.

Defending the decision to drop the Parandur project, the Minister said the villages

in and around Parandur had a long history of rice cultivation, along with cultivation of groundnut, pulses and sugarcane.

Keerthana said the availability of good water bodies enabled cultivation even in periods of inadequate rainfall. The area also has two canals that naturally divert water towards the Adyar river and Chembarambakkam lake.

FLOODING RISK

"Those water flows should not be obstructed," she said, warning that disrupting the drainage network could increase the risk of flooding in Chennai.

Law and Electricity Minister CTR Nirmal Kumar also defended the government's decision, and said the previous government had neither obtained environmental clearance nor undertaken the required environment impact assessment for the project.

Of the 5,846 acres identified for the Parandur airport, *patta* land accounted for 3,774 acres, while agricultural land constituted 2,681 acres.

Government land accounted for 1,972 acres, including nearly 1,558 acres of water bodies, Kumar said.



another layer of uncertainty to global markets.

Overall, positive foreign flows, softer crude prices and a weaker dollar are providing support to the rupee. However, geopolitical uncertainty, particularly its potential impact on oil prices, and RBI using incoming dollars to build the reserves, continues to limit the scope for appreciation.

CHART

The rupee, has broken its 95.56-95.76 range on the upside on Tuesday.

Thus, the support at 95.80 has held very well. Need to see if the rise on Tuesday sustains or not. Near-term resistance is at 95.30 which can be tested this week if the currency manages to sustain higher.

A break above 95.30 can then take the rupee further higher to 94.90, the next resistance.

Failure to breach 95.30 and a downward reversal from

there can take the rupee down to 95.75-95.80 again.

In case the bears gain traction and the support at 95.80 is breached, the rupee can drop to 96.20 or even to 96.50.

The dollar index, which lost 0.8 per cent last week and closed at 98.84 on Friday, has now inched higher to 99. It is likely to rise to 99.40-99.50 band, which can cap the rally. That said, a breakout of 99.50 can bring back the bullishness.

However, a decline, either from the current level of 99 or after rising to 99.40-99.50 region, might drag the dollar index to 98.50 or even to 98.

OUTLOOK

The rupee can test 95.30 in the near-term.

The price action, thereafter, will need a close watch to see if the domestic currency is extending the gains or not. The expected trading range for the week can be 95.30-95.80.

S.I. CAPITAL & FINANCIAL SERVICES LIMITED

Regd. Office: No.28, Second Floor, New Scheme Road, Pollachi, Coimbatore 642001
Website: www.sicapital.co.in Tel: 04259 - 233304/05
CIN: L67190TZ1994PLC040490

NOTICE OF THE 32nd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND INFORMATION REGARDING E-VOTING

The 32nd Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of the Company is scheduled on **Friday, September 18, 2026, at 11.30AM (IST)** through Video Conferencing / Other Audio Visual Means ("VC/OAVM") to transact the business, as set out in the Notice of AGM ("Notice") in compliance with General Circular Numbers 14/2020, 17/2020, 20/2020 33/2020, 39/2020, 10/2021, 20/2021, 03/2022, 10/2022 11/2022 and 09/2024 and all other applicable laws and circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA), Government of India and Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), without the physical presence of the members at a common venue. The Company has appointed Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL) to provide the VC/OAVM facility, along with the remote e-voting facility, for the AGM.

The Company has duly sent the electronic copies of the Notice of the AGM containing detailed instructions and information relating to e-voting, along with a weblink to access the integrated Annual Report 2025-26 by email to those members whose email IDs are registered with the Company/Depositories. The said dispatch through emails has been completed on August 25, 2026. Additionally, in accordance with Regulation 36(1)(b) of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (Listing Regulations), the Company is also sending a letter to shareholders, whose e-mail IDs are not registered with Company/RTA/DP, providing the weblink of the Company's website from where the Integrated Annual Report for FY 2025-26 can be accessed. The Company shall send a physical copy of the Integrated Annual Report 2025-26 to those Members who specifically request the same at info@sicapital.co.in, mentioning their Folio No./ DP ID and Client ID. The Notice is also available on the website of the Company at www.sicapital.co.in, BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com, and CDSL at www.evotingindia.com.

REMOTE E-VOTING INFORMATION

Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Reg.44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended from time to time, the members whose names appear in the Register of Members/Beneficial owners as on the cut-off date, i.e., September 11, 2026, are provided with the facility to cast their votes through remote e-voting and e-voting during AGM, on the businesses to be transacted at the AGM of the Company. The detailed process of remote e-voting and e-voting during AGM is given in the Notes of the Notice of AGM.

Manner of registering/updating email IDs:

- Members holding shares in dematerialized mode are requested to register their email addresses and mobile numbers with their relevant depositories through their depository participants.
- Members holding shares in physical mode are requested to furnish their email addresses and mobile numbers to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, MUFG Intime India Private Limited (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) at coimbatore@in.mpps.mufg.com.

The facility to cast votes remotely is arranged through Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL), and the remote e-voting facility will be available during the following time period:

Commencement of e-voting period : From 9.00 a.m. (IST) on September 15, 2026
End of e-voting : Up to 5.00 p.m. (IST) on September 17, 2026

The remote E-voting facility shall be blocked by CDSL on expiry of the aforesaid date and time. Any person who acquires shares of the Company and becomes a member after dispatch of the Notice of the meeting and holding shares as on the cut-off date, i.e., September 11, 2026, may obtain the User ID and password by sending a request to CDSL at helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or to Link Intime India Pvt. Ltd at coimbatore@in.mpps.mufg.com.

Members are permitted to join the AGM through VC/OAVM, 15 minutes before the scheduled time of commencement of the AGM, and 15 minutes after the commencement of the AGM through the facility provided by CDSL. Members who have voted through remote e-voting can attend the AGM, but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again through e-voting during the AGM.

In case of any queries/grievances regarding e-voting, members may contact the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent: Link Intime India Pvt. Ltd, Phone: 0422 4958995, 2539835 / 836 E-mail ID: coimbatore@in.mpps.mufg.com or Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Manager, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Mafatall Mill Compounds, N M Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400013 or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or call on 1800 21 09911.

For SI Capital & Financial Services Limited
Pollachi
26-08-2026
Sujith K Ravindranath,
Company Secretary

Brands, retailers witness a spike in *rakhi* gifting demand

Quick-commerce platforms are offering a wider assortment this year

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

Brands, retailers and e-commerce players are expecting to garner double-digit sales growth in the run-up to *Raksha Bandhan*, which is slated to be celebrated this Friday. Players across categories, including chocolates, beauty and accessories, have introduced gifting-focused offerings.

From wearables brand boAt to international fashion brand Michael Kors, both domestic and international companies have stepped up *rakhi* themed marketing initiatives and campaigns. Premiumisation and personalisation are increasingly gaining traction in gifting.

Harmeet Singh, Chief Brand Officer, The Body Shop Asia South, said, "*Raksha Bandhan* remains a strong festive moment for



PREMIUM PICKS. Instamart said premium *rakhis* have surged 20x over last year with strong demand for silver designs

us, and we're expecting close to 15 per cent growth in *rakhi* hamper sales this year, with quick commerce joining stores and online as a real driver of last-minute gifting. For 2026, we've elevated our strategy with gourmand, ingredient-focused launches coupled with our popular customise your own (CYO) curated gift boxes."

Zoher Kapuswala, Mar-

keting Head, Ferrero, India Subcontinent, said, "*Raksha Bandhan* sales compared to last year. We are also witnessing a strong interest for personalised gifts, premium curated hampers, luxe hampers, beauty and self-care, lifestyle products and experiential gifts. Same-day and express delivery, along with international *rakhi* delivery, are therefore becoming an important part of how modern

sumer sentiment and continued demand for quality-led products."

He added that the company is expecting to garner high double-digit growth this festival season.

HEALTHY DEMAND

Avi Kumar, Chief Marketing Officer, FNP, said the company is witnessing a healthy demand for both planned and last-minute gifting options.

"We are looking at double-digit growth in *Raksha Bandhan* sales compared to last year. We are also witnessing a strong interest for personalised gifts, premium curated hampers, luxe hampers, beauty and self-care, lifestyle products and experiential gifts. Same-day and express delivery, along with international *rakhi* delivery, are therefore becoming an important part of how modern

sibling relationships are celebrated," Kumar added.

Quick-commerce platforms too are offering a wider assortment this year. Instamart on Tuesday said premium *rakhis* have surged 20x over last year with strong demand for silver designs and a spike in searches for jewellery brands.

Nishant Sardana, Director, Amazon Now, said, "Our *Rakhi* Store brings together over 500 unique *rakhis*, festive essentials and gifting options in one place, all delivered in minutes."

INFLUX OF SHOPPERS

Noting that traders have reported a rise in the influx of shoppers, the Confederation of All India Traders said that the overall *Raksha Bandhan*-related trade is expected to exceed ₹30,000 crore.

QUICKLY.

Lanka invites global firms for petroleum exploration



Colombo: Sri Lanka on Tuesday invited international companies to explore oil and gas in four blocks in the Mannar Basin in the island's North-West, according to an official statement. The move is part of Sri Lanka's larger effort to develop the island's offshore petroleum resources. **PTI**

Canada's \$20-b retaliatory tariffs on US goods

Ottawa: Canada on Tuesday announced retaliatory tariffs on C\$27.6 billion (\$19.94 billion) worth of US goods, matching dollar-for-dollar new duties imposed by Washington, and unveiled financial support for Canadian businesses and workers caught in the escalating trade war. The counter-tariffs take effect from September 8 and will impose duties of 15 per cent, 25 per cent and 50 per cent across 700 products, a government statement said. Canada announced a C\$7.5-billion package of new and enhanced measures including support for small and medium-sized businesses, a stream for funding cash flows of companies, and support for workers who could be at risk due to the new tariffs. **REUTERS**

Iran pledges to fight back against widened US sanctions

NEW TENSIONS. It is confident major trading partners will resist the pressure campaign

Reuters

Cairo/Washington

Iran pledged to fight back against the expanded US sanctions aimed at isolating its economy, expressing confidence that major trading partners would resist the pressure campaign and saying that Washington was keen to revive talks. Almost six months into a conflict, the US has struggled to resolve, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent unveiled the measures on Monday but stopped short of the most punishing sanctions.

While he said countries that continued trading with Iran risked being forced out of the dollar-based financial system, he declined to give a timeline or identify which may be targeted, saying he would give them time to comply with the new directive. Abbas Golroo, head of the Foreign Relations Committee in the Iranian Parliament, said Pakistan's army chief Asim Munir had delivered a message from the US to Iran on Monday. "It seems the main goal was to revive the stopped political process," he told ISNA news agency. There was no immediate comment from the White House or the State Department.

The Treasury Department did announce new sanctions



SOH PASSAGE. An oil tanker was struck on Tuesday by an unidentified projectile and disabled off Oman's Ash Shishah, which lies at the entrance to the Strait of Hormuz **REUTERS**

on 60 individuals, entities and vessels, but the list did not feature any of the Chinese financial institutions suspected of facilitating Iran's oil trade.

"We want to make clear here today that no one is above the reach of US sanctions," Bessent said in response to a question about Chinese banks. China has been the biggest buyer of Iranian oil for several years, although the US blockade of Iran's ports has cut Iranian oil flows to China since Washington renewed it in mid-July.

Experts say the US is wary of Chinese retaliation for any sanctions on its banks ahead of expected talks next month

between President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping, with any curbs on China's exports of critical minerals especially sensitive.

China said on Tuesday that its cooperation with Iran is conducted within the framework of international law and should not be interfered with or disrupted. Oil prices fell for a second day as traders brushed off the impact of the sanctions, although market participants remained wary of Iran's continued ability to disrupt shipping.

OIL TANKER STRUCK

An oil tanker was struck on Tuesday by an unidentified

projectile and disabled about 9 nautical miles (17 km) North-East of Oman's Ash Shishah, which lies at the entrance to the Strait of Hormuz, the UK Maritime Trade Operations said.

After the latest sanctions were unveiled, Iranian Economy Minister Ali Madanizadeh said Iran was prepared to respond.

"Our defence is no longer so defensive; the enemies should wait for an attack," he told State television. Neither China nor Russia had "accepted" the US measures, he added, predicting that other countries would resist them.

There have been no major US or Iranian strikes for weeks, but Brigadier General Hossein Mohebbi, a spokesperson for Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, vowed heavy blows to US vital interests and energy choke-points if Iran's infrastructure is threatened, Press TV reported.

MEDIATION PROGRESS

Mediator Pakistan made "significant progress" in the latest talks with Tehran that focused on preventing further escalation and reopening the Strait of Hormuz, the Pakistani military said.

"We had a very constructive exchange," Pakistani Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi, who accompanied Munir to Tehran, said on X.

US targets 4 Indian firms in 'Operation Economic Outcast' against Iran

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The US has sanctioned four India-based companies for their alleged involvement in importing Iranian petroleum and petrochemical products, as Washington expands its economic pressure on Tehran under a new campaign, Operation Economic Outcast, aimed at choking Iran's finances.

India is keeping an eye on the development and waiting for more clarity on the sanctions that have been imposed, sources said.

"It is not yet clear what kind of sanctions these are. The notification is awaited. The government would keep an eye on how the development plays out before deciding on its response," a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

The four Indian companies named by the US State Department are Portease Partners LLP, Sadashiva Overseas, PP Softtech and Prakrutees Infra Impex India.

The US action also designated three Indian nationals associated with the companies — Indrismiya Ashrafmiya Shekh and Harish Ramchandra Rangi of Portease Partners and Prashant Garg of PP Softtech.

'Operation Economic Outcast' is an "economic onslaught against Iran's financial connections around the globe", US Treasury Secret-



An economic engagement of any kind with this murderous regime will expose those responsible to the full reach of American power

SCOTT BESSENT

US Treasury Secretary

ary Scott Bessent said while announcing the fresh package of measures on Monday against the country it has been at war with for almost six months.

Bessent warned that countries maintaining financial ties with Iran would risk isolation, while banks and businesses continuing to deal with Tehran could face similar consequences if they failed to sever those links.

SUSTAINED CAMPAIGN

"This is a sustained campaign to collapse every last option for Iran. Let there be

no ambiguity as to the position of the US: An economic engagement of any kind with this murderous regime will expose those responsible to the full reach of American power," Bessent said.

Responding to the new measures, Iranian Economy Minister Ali Madanizadeh said Tehran was fully prepared for the sanctions, which he said would lead to "another defeat" for the US.

REDUCED TRADE

India stopped purchasing oil from Iran and its trade in other goods, including agricultural commodities, too, started dwindling after the US began reimposing sanctions on Iran in August 2018, after President Donald Trump withdrew the US from the 2015 Iran nuclear deal (JCPOA) on May 8, 2018.

In FY26, India's exports to Iran was at just \$1.25 billion, comprising primarily of basmati rice and some other farm products and pharmaceuticals. Its imports from Iran were at about \$375 million comprising small quantities of fruits, petroleum products and ores.

New Delhi is also handing over the operations of the Shahid Beheshti terminal at the Chabahar Port to the Iranian government following Washington's refusal to extend the sanctions waiver that lapsed in April, sources said.

It hopes to gain back control after the situation normalises.

C-DOT to drive India's shift from self-reliance to global telecom leadership: Scindia

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The government on Tuesday said the technological expertise of the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT), State-owned telecommunications technology development centre, will play a crucial role in shifting India from self-reliance to making the world rely on Indian innovation.

Speaking on the 43rd foundation day of C-DOT, Telecom Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia said India has been able to break into the club of four countries supplying advanced telecom gear for 4G and 5G across the globe and become the fifth country to develop its own 4G stack.

"I am very confident that my (C-DOT) family present here today will lead India from an India that was *vishwa par nirbhar* (dependent on the world) to an India today that is *Atmanirbhar* to a C-DOT that will contribute to India tomorrow on a *vishwa Bharat par nirbhar* (world dependent on India)," Scindia said.

He added India was behind the world in 4G, walked and marched with the world



QUANTUM OF WORK. Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia at the 43rd Foundation Day of C-DOT, where 14 quantum products were unveiled

on 5G but due to organisations such as C-DoT, the government and every proud Indian can say that India will lead the world in 6G.

He further said that as India marches to the journey of Viksit Bharat 2047, C-DoT has to march from lab to market, and from research to development, globally marketing those developmental products. "The next era of telecom is not going to be defined merely by connecting people, but by ensuring that connectivity and the networks that we evolve are trusted, resilient, intelligent and, most importantly, secure," Scindia added.

On the occasion, C-DoT unveiled 14 quantum products, some of which

nearly 57 lakh lost or stolen phones till now. "It might seem simple for many people, but for many families, that phone is not just a simple device; it is probably one of the most expensive items that they own. We take things for granted, but I know how much work it takes to build these systems," he said.

He said there are more than 25 crore daily website visits on Sanchar Saathi portal and around 2.5 crore downloads of the app every day, and it is estimated to have prevented financial fraud worth ₹5,000 crore till date.

Meanwhile, RK Upadhyay, CEO, C-DOT, said, "In the last five years, we have raised our revenue from ₹80 crore to ₹600 crore, and under the guidance of our ministers, we have set a target to ourselves to achieve ₹5,000 crore in the next few years."

SANCHAR SAATHI

The Minister of State for Communications, Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani, said the Sanchar Saathi app, developed by C-DOT, had helped trace around 36 lakh stolen devices and blocked

GMR AERO
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30th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF GMR AIRPORTS LIMITED (FORMERLY GMR AIRPORTS INFRASTRUCTURE LIMITED)

Notice is hereby given that the 30th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of GMR Airports Limited (Formerly GMR Airports Infrastructure Limited) ("the Company") will be held through Video Conferencing/Other Audio-Visual Means ("VC/OAVM") on Monday, September 21, 2026, at 03:00 P.M. IST, in compliance with all the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("the Act") and the Rules made thereunder and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI Listing Regulations"), read with General Circular No. 14/2020 dated April 08, 2020 and 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, General Circular No. 20/2020 dated May 05, 2020, and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being, General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 and other applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") (collectively referred to as "MCA Circulars") to transact the business, as set out in the Notice of AGM which is being circulated for convening the AGM. In terms of the said Circulars, the 30th AGM of the Company will be held through VC/OAVM. Hence, Members can attend and participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM only. The instructions for joining the AGM will be set out in the Notice of the AGM.

In compliance with the MCA Circulars, Notice of the AGM along with the Annual Report for the FY 2025-26 will be sent only through electronic mode to all those Security holders whose email addresses are registered with the Company/ Registrar to an Issue and Share Transfer Agent (RTA)/ Depository Participant(s). The aforesaid documents will also be available on the Company's website at www.gmraero.com, websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and at www.nseindia.com respectively and on the website of the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, KFin Technologies Limited ("KFinTech") at <https://evoting.kfintech.com/>. Further, the hard copy of Annual Report including Notice of AGM shall be sent to those security holders who specifically request for the same.

Further, MCA vide the above referred circulars has granted relaxation in respect of sending physical copies of the Annual Reports to the Members and provisions related to proxy for general meetings held through electronic mode.

Further, in terms of Regulations 36(b) of SEBI LODR, the Company will also be sending a physical communication to the Members whose email addresses are not updated in the records, which shall contain the web-link and a QR code, including the exact path of the Company's website to access the Notice, Annual Report for FY 2025-26, and other relevant documents.

Members who have not registered their email addresses are requested to register the same in respect of shares held in electronic form with the Depository through their respective Depository Participant(s).

Members holding securities in physical form are hereby notified that pursuant to SEBI Master Circular No. HO/38/13(4)/2026-MRSD-PD/14/298/2026 dated February 06, 2026, all the holders of physical securities can update/register their Email address, Mobile number, PAN and Bank Account details through Form ISR-1 and ISR-2. Members may also furnish nomination details as provided under Rule 19 of the Companies (Share Capital and Debentures) Rules, 2014, through Form SH-13, opt out of nomination by submitting Form ISR-3, or make changes to an existing nomination through Form SH-14 by submitting the requisite forms along with the supporting documents to KFinTech.

The above mentioned forms can be downloaded from the Company's website at <https://www.gmraero.com/investor-relations/shareholders/downloads> or from the website of KFinTech at <https://ris.kfintech.com/client-services/isr/srforms.aspx>.

The Company will be providing the facility to all its Members to cast their votes by electronic means both through remote e-voting and e-voting during the AGM. Detailed procedure for remote e-voting/ e-voting for Members holding shares in dematerialized mode and process for Members who have not registered their email address will be provided in the Notice of the AGM.

In case of queries or grievances pertaining to e-voting, Members are requested to contact Mr. Anandan K, Assistant Vice President, KFinTech at Toll Free No: 1800-309-4001; Email: enwardr@kfintech.com.

Further, the Company has fixed Monday, September 14, 2026, as the "Record Date" for the purpose of payment of final dividend to the holders of 0.000% Unlisted Non-Cumulative Optionally Convertible Redeemable Preference Shares ("OCRPS") of INR 40/- (Indian Rupees Forty only) each, for the Financial Year ended March 31, 2026, if declared at the AGM. The dividend once approved by the Members at the AGM, will be paid within the statutory timelines of 90 days from the date of AGM.

The said OCRPS holder is requested to update its KYC & Bank Account details with its depository participant/ RTA to enable receipt of dividend in electronic mode on the payout date, in case not already updated.

For GMR Airports Limited
(Formerly GMR Airports Infrastructure Limited)
Sd/-
T. Venkat Ramana
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer (ACS: 13979)

Place: New Delhi
Date: August 25, 2026
GMR GROUP-GAL/62/PREM ASSOCIATES

Doval, Wang hold India, China Special Representatives talks

Press Trust of India
Beijing

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval on Tuesday took part in the Special Representatives talks with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi on the India-China boundary

question and improvement of relations between the countries.

The talks assume significance as they are being held ahead of Chinese President Xi Jinping's much-anticipated visit to New Delhi to attend the BRICS summit on September 12-13.

They also come at a time when differences over the border and Arunachal Pradesh continue to figure prominently in India-China bilateral ties.

Both Doval and Wang are the designated Special Representatives for the boundary talks mechanism, which

was established in 2003 to comprehensively address the dispute of the India-China border spanning 3,488 km.

Prior to the talks, Doval, who arrived here on a two-day visit on Monday, called on Chinese Vice-President Han Zhang.

GMR POWER & URBAN INFRA
Regd. Office: Unit No. 19, 18th Floor, Tower A, Building No. 5, DLF Cyber City, DLF Phase-II, Gurugram, Haryana - 122002, India. Phone : +91 124 6637750
E: GPULLI_CS@gmrgroup.in W: www.gmrpowerurbaninfra.com CIN: L45400HR2019PLC125712

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(Formerly GMR Power and Urban Infra Infrastructure Limited)
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7th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF GMR POWER AND URBAN INFRA LIMITED

Notice is hereby given that the 7th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the GMR Power and Urban Infra Limited (Formerly GMR Power and Urban Infra Infrastructure Limited) ("the Company") will be held through Video Conferencing/Other Audio-Visual Means ("VC/OAVM") on Monday, September 21, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. IST, in compliance with all the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and the Rules made thereunder and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI Listing Regulations"), read with General Circular Nos. 14/2020 dated April 08, 2020 and 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, General Circular Nos. 20/2020 dated May 05, 2020, and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being, General Circular No. 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 and other applicable circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") (collectively referred to as "MCA Circulars") to transact the business, as set out in the Notice of AGM which is being circulated for convening the AGM. In terms of the said Circulars, the 7th AGM of the Company will be held through VC/OAVM. Hence, Members can attend and participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM only. The instructions for joining the AGM will be set out in the Notice of the AGM.

In compliance with the MCA Circulars, Notice of the AGM along with the Annual Report for the FY 2025-26 will be sent only through electronic mode to all those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/ Registrar to an Issue and Share Transfer Agent (RTA)/ Depository Participant(s). The aforesaid documents will also be available on the Company's website at www.gmrpowerurbaninfra.com, websites of the Stock Exchanges i.e. BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and at www.nseindia.com respectively and on the website of the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, KFin Technologies Limited ("KFinTech") at <https://evoting.kfintech.com/>. Further, the hard copy of Annual Report including Notice of AGM shall be sent to those Members who specifically request for the same.

Further, MCA vide above referred circulars has granted relaxation in respect of sending physical copies of the annual reports to the Members and provisions related to proxy for general meetings held through electronic mode.

Further, in terms of Regulations 36(b) of SEBI LODR, the Company will also be sending a physical communication to the Members whose email addresses are not updated in the records, which shall contain the web-link and a QR code, including the exact path of the Company's website to access the Notice, Annual Report for FY 2025 - 26, and other relevant documents.

Members who have not registered their email addresses are requested to register the same in respect of shares held in electronic form with the Depository through their respective Depository Participant(s).

The Company will be providing the facility to all its members to cast their votes by electronic means both through remote e-voting and e-voting during the AGM. Detailed procedure for remote e-voting/ e-voting for Members holding shares in dematerialized mode and process for Members who have not registered their email address will be provided in the Notice of the AGM.

In case of queries or grievances pertaining to e-voting, Members are requested to contact Mr. Anandan K, Assistant Vice President, KFinTech at Toll Free No: 1800-309-4001; Email: enwardr@kfintech.com.

This advertisement is being issued for the information and benefit of all the Members of the Company in compliance with the MCA Circulars.

For GMR Power and Urban Infra Limited
Sd/-
Vimal Prakash
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer (ACS: 20876)

Place: New Delhi
Date: August 25, 2026
GMR GROUP-PULL/34/PREM ASSOCIATES

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Indian Bank

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UPI at Ten: A Decade That Rewired How India Pays

Ten years ago this week, a modest interface called the Unified Payments Interface went live with 21 banks and barely ninety thousand transactions in its first month. Few could have guessed then that it would become the engine room of India's digital economy. Today the platform processes, within a single day, more transactions than most of the countries manage in a year.

The numbers tell their own story. Annual transaction volume has climbed from 1.78 crore in FY2016-17 to over 24,162 crore in FY2025-26, an almost 13,000-fold surge. Transaction value moved through the system that rose from a modest Rs 0.07 lakh crore to around 314 lakh crore over the same period, a nearly 4,000-fold increase. The number of banks live on the platform grew from 21 in April 2016 to 741 in July 2026. Last month alone, UPI saw a record 2,366 crore transactions, an average of 66 crore transactions processed every single day of the year. The International Monetary Fund has itself recognised UPI as the world's largest real time payment system by volume, accounting for close to half of all real time payments processed anywhere on the planet.

Fig: Annual UPI transaction volume and value, FY2016-17 to FY2025-26.

What sets UPI apart from digital payment systems built elsewhere is not just its scale but its architecture. Rather than concentrating volumes inside one dominant app, India built common digital framework that any licensed player could plug into and compete, which has kept the system open, interoperable and resistant to any single point of failure. That design choice, more than any marketing push, explains how UPI scaled to hundreds of banks and reached nearly every corner of the country within a decade.

Behind this growth sits a less discussed driver: the merchant network itself. Recent research suggests that merchant acceptance, not consumer enthusiasm alone, has been the real force multiplier. Districts with a denser network of merchants accepting UPI have consistently shown faster adoption among consumers, which shows that the last mile of acceptance infrastructure mattered as much as the app sitting on a customer's phone.

In our Bank, the number of active UPI customers grew 21 per cent year on year, from 2.29 crore in FY25 to 2.77 crore in FY26, while the volume of UPI transactions grew 35 per cent YoY in the last quarter, from 176 crores to 237 crores.

Mobile banking users climbed 23 per cent to 2.48 crore over the same period. Taken together, 95 per cent of all customer transactions at the Bank during the quarter were carried out

digitally, up from 93 per cent a year earlier, with digital channels originating business worth 67,327 crore in the quarter, itself up 16 per cent year on year.

UPI's architecture has also started to travel. Since February 2023, UPI has been bilaterally linked with Singapore's **PayNow**, letting users of either system send real-time, low-cost remittances. The first such link for India's fast payment system.

Indian travellers can already scan a UPI QR code to pay merchants directly in Bhutan, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Qatar, Singapore, Sri Lanka and the UAE, and the list has kept growing since. By August 2026, government figures put the tally at eleven countries, with Cambodia, Greece and the Maldives added to that earlier list. For a payment system barely a decade old, that is a rare achievement. UPI is not only processing India's own transactions at world beating scale but also becoming genuine cross border infrastructure that other countries are choosing to plug into rather than compete against.

Over the next decade, multi-currency support and cross-border linkages, like the **PayNow** integration, will be the prime drivers enabling Indian travellers to transact seamlessly at foreign merchant counters. Expanding this network to additional countries with friction-free currency conversion remains one of UPI's most significant untapped opportunities.

Additionally, offline functionality and transit use cases still hold immense potential. Quick, queue-free QR payments for metros, buses, and toll plazas are a natural evolution of UPI's retail success, poised to revolutionize India's daily commute.

For merchants, the RBI's recent Master Direction on Payment Aggregators establishes a standardized, risk-based KYC framework for onboarding. Combined with ongoing support for non-bank and fintech entities in merchant acquisition, these regulations will materially ease the transition of lower-tier small merchants onto digital networks.

UPI's story is far from finished. Continued investment in resilience, a widening circle of international partners and a sustainable revenue model will together decide whether UPI remains not just India's payment backbone, but the template other countries look to when building their own digital public infrastructure.

